

AGE SETS, ACCOUNTABILITY, AND THE BALANCE OF POWER: EVIDENCE FROM VILLAGES IN RURAL CONGO*

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ABSTRACT:

Across Africa, village chiefs are the foundation of village-level politics. They are typically older and, as a consequence, less educated. This, along with concerns of despotism, has led to initiatives aimed at empowering younger individuals or creating committees that provide checks on the village chief. We study the consequences of these efforts, explicitly accounting for the fact that the effects of empowering younger cohorts is likely contingent on the underlying social structure of the village. Particularly relevant is that across Africa, age sets, which comprise initiation rituals for young men, are common. A documented consequence of age sets is that they generate a balance of power by creating a cohesive group of young men that provided a check on older political elites. Our study, working within a randomized intervention, shows that the effects of empowering young men and checking the power of the chief depends critically on the underlying social structure of the village – namely, whether age sets are present. In villages without age sets, empowering young men is ineffective and leads to more capture by the village elite. In villages with age sets, young men do indeed work more effectively together to provide more political oversight. However, the increased cohesion generates outcomes that are similar to the status quo. Thus, we find that in a gerontocratic setting such as ours, empowering young men can backfire, especially if social structures that unify young men – namely, age sets – are not present.

Keywords: Social organization, age sets, accountability, governance.

JEL Classification: O120, Z130, Z190.

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1. Introduction

There is growing consensus that it is important to account for the local context when designing development policies and interventions. This perspective stems from the observation that societies, particularly in the developing world, exhibit rich social and cultural variation that shapes the context in which policies are embedded. This variation is potentially important for a range of policies and in ways that are not obvious a priori.

In this paper, we aim to make progress on our understanding of these issues by looking at how one particular cultural practice – age sets – is relevant for policies aimed at improving village-level governance. Age sets are groups of people (typically young men) who participate in a lengthy initiation (generally lasting many months). During the rituals, participants learn a host of skills, including house construction, farming, spirituality, genealogy, and proper social conduct. One consequence of the process is that the men who undergo the process together become highly bonded and for the rest of their life form a cohesive group (age set) that progress together through different stages of life (called age grades).

While the consequences of this horizontal social structure for redistribution have recently been documented ([Moscona and Seck, 2024](#)), within the anthropological literature, the primary consequence of age sets is not economic but political. Age sets, comprised of a cohesive group of young men, provide a counterbalance to the political power of the elites in the village, who are generally from an older generation. Although the system is generally gerontocratic, meaning power increases with age, the younger cohort, which due to age sets, is cohesive and not aligned with the older elite, provides a check on the elite of a village.

Across Africa, and in the setting of our study, the northern DRC, there is rich variation, even at a granular level, in the extent to which the age set custom is present. Given their political consequences, variation in age sets is potentially relevant to a class of policies and interventions, which aim to improve governance across African villages. Within economics, there have been attempts to shift power from older, and often less educated, individuals to younger more educated members of the village ([Casey, Glennester, Miguel and Voors, 2023](#)) or to improve the accountability of chiefs through village development committees ([Casey, Glennester and Miguel, 2012](#), [Humphreys, Sanchez de la Sierra and Van der Windt, 2019](#)).

Our study shows how the efficacy of such efforts depends on the presence of age sets in

a village. Across 102 rural villages in Sud-Ubangi province in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, we implement an intervention that provides village chiefs with grants to purchase health products (deworming pills, chlorine tablets for water purification, and oral rehydration salts) made available at subsidized rates and transported to the village. As part of the project, village oversight committees are formed to monitor the Chief's management of the project and its resources. We randomly vary the composition of the oversight committees. In half of the sample villages, the committee is a random selection of all volunteers, and in the other half, the committees only include young men.

We are interested in whether the consequences of committee type depend on the social context of this village. Specifically, we test whether it is the case that in age set villages, young male committees work more effectively and provide better oversight of the village chief. In age set villages, young men belonging to the same age set tend to be bonded and highly cohesive. This may generate a more cohesive committee that is better at undertaking its tasks, including participating in committee meetings and meeting with other committee members, organizing village meetings, communicating with villagers, and distributing the health products.

The nature of the experiment meant that the chief is in control of the finances and he had the ability to divert some of the funding from the project to himself. Since the age set custom creates a cohesive group of young men that counterbalance the power of the elders who hold political positions, it is possible that young male committees are better able to limit the discretion of the chief in villages with an age set custom.

The experiment took place in two rounds from June 2016 to November 2023. We administered a baseline survey in 2016. We provided two rounds of cash grants, in 2019 and 2022, with endline surveys approximately 6 months after each round. At baseline, we had separate surveys for the village chief, the village secretary, the village sage, the groupement chief, a notable from each clan of the village and 12 randomly chosen villagers. For the endline surveys, we interviewed a random sample of 12 villagers, committee members, and the village chief.

At baseline, we find that villagers in age set villages are more likely to report norms supportive of a more gerontocratic political structure. For example, they are more likely to believe elders should be responsible for decisions. They also report greater presence of gerontocratic practices – elders have more power in their villages and the chief gets support from the elders rather than the young. Interestingly, despite this, those in age set villages report being less trusting of elders.

We now turn to the effect of treatment – exploring how forming young male committees in age set villages affects the functioning of the project, missing money, and product allocation. First, as expected, we find that our young male committee treatment arm results in a different committee composition. Young male committees are all male and tend to be significantly younger. Diverse committees are older and comprise both genders, although about two-thirds of committee members are men.

We had enumerators record the chiefs reaction to the announcement of the committees. We find that chiefs were generally satisfied with the committees, but much less so when it is a young male committee in a village with the age set custom. This is what one would expect given ethnographic accounts.

We find evidence that male committees in age set villages were more cohesive and function more effectively together. They report feeling closer to the other members of the committee. Not surprisingly, they do not report feeling closer to the chief, but they do report feeling closer to villagers. Their greater cohesion is also reflected in the work they carried out. They performed more oversight tasks, such as organizing meetings, organizing product distribution, carrying out the distribution, and meeting with peasants to answer questions or concerns about the health products. There was no difference in frequency of meeting with the chief or keeping written records. Thus, in terms of committee cohesion and governance tasks performed, young male committees in age set villages are more effective.

We find some evidence that young male committees in age set villages affect some of the behaviors of the chief. Specifically, chiefs were more likely to organize meetings. However, chiefs were less likely to distribute the products themselves. Thus, in villages with young male committees and age sets, the committee seems to have taken more responsibility in terms of distribution relative to the chief. We find no effect on the frequency that the chief met with villagers or the committee or the extent to which he kept written records.

We then turn to the effects on the amount of money missing. Perhaps surprisingly, we find that the level of graft from project funds by the chief was fairly low – less than 10%. This was significantly lower than the 23 percent that was anticipated by expert academic economists working in the field of development economics or political economy. We find that greater oversight and constraints on the chief in the form of a young male committee in age set villages had no effect on the amount of graft. Thus, there is no evidence that oversight was too weak and the chiefs

powers were too strong.

Lastly, while we find limited evidence of our intervention and underlying variation in the age set custom affecting the amount of missing money, we do find important distributional implications – suggesting that young male committees in age set villages have important effects on the allocation of resources. We collect data from households on the number and types of products that they receive, as well as information on whether they are connected to the village chief or committee members. We find that chiefs in age set villages with young male committees received fewer products. On average, chiefs receive 45 products (relative to 19 for villagers). Chiefs in age set villages with young male committees receive 20 fewer products.

We also find important heterogeneity in how products are allocated among villagers. We partition our sample by whether or not respondents are close to the chief, wealthy, and close to committee members. In age set villages with young male committees, households that are closer to the chief and wealthier tend to receive fewer products. Interestingly, we do not find evidence that these resources are captured by villagers who are close to the committee members. That is, in age set villages with young male committees, we do not see evidence of products being distributed to those more closely connected to members of the committee.

The differential effects of young male committee in age set villages is driven by the fact that in non-age set villages, when young young male committees are formed, the distribution of health products is heavily skewed towards the village elite. This suggests that in gerontocratic environments, which is the case for all villages in this setting, young male committees are particularly ineffective when age sets are not present because they do not have the traditional role of countering the power of the village elders. Despite being better educated, these young men cannot effectively constrain the power of the chief. When age sets are present, then the young male committees generate a much more equitable distribution. However, even in this case, the distribution is as equitable as that generated by diverse committees (in either age set or non-age set villages).

Overall, our findings show that the effects of the program we examine – which like other recent initiatives aims to give some formal power to younger individuals in the village – depend on the presence of an important local custom, age sets. When age sets are present, then young male committees do generate groups that are more cohesive and engage more in oversight activities. In terms of product distribution, young male committees appear not to be able to prevent unfair

product distribution, which is not surprising given the fact our setting is strongly gerontocratic. When age sets are present, this adverse outcome is not present. These findings highlight the care that must be taken when attempting to alter the distribution of power in local villages. Our findings show that whether a particular intervention is beneficial or not can depend critically on the baseline social and political structure.

The paper makes a number of contributions to our existing knowledge. First, it provides an attempt to integrate local social structures into policy in a simple, yet real, way. Age sets have been noted as being important components of traditional governance, but have not been integrated into policy. A recent World Bank working paper laments this fact, writing that “Of the 78 [World Bank] assessments of legal and justice systems undertaken by the Bank since 1994, many mention the prevalence of traditional justice in the countries looked at, but *none* explore the systems in detail or examine the links between local level systems and state regimes.” ([Chirayath, Sage and Woolcock, 2005](#), p. 3) (emphasis in the original). The document then goes on to identify age sets as being an important dimension of traditional politics, for the groups in their case studies, since they “partially offset the central authority of the chief and the divisions amongst the lineages” (p. 13).

Second, we contribute to the literature on the efficacy of CDD programs. [Casey \(2018\)](#) provides an overview of the key findings from the literature. Despite much policy enthusiasm for community driven development and the hope that these programs improves local decision making, there is little evidence of enduring impact. As described in [Casey \(2018\)](#), while CDDs are able to effectively deliver local public goods, there is little impact on institutions. Generally, in CDD interventions, the committees that are formed are designed to be diverse. Thus, our project differs slightly from this standard implementation and provides evidence on how targeting groups that traditionally hold the role of holding leaders accountable may improve outcomes. [Humphreys et al. \(2019\)](#) implement a large scale CDD in Eastern Congo across 1250 villages. They find no evidence that the program improves governance outcomes across a wide variety of indicators, such as whether public funds are captured and the types of governance practices employed by village leaders. Our project will speak to understanding when and how CDD type projects may be most effective. The results will also speak to how CDD programs may be tailored to better leverage existing institutions – rather than aiming to change them.

The paper also complements a literature on understanding the role of social structures for

development outcomes. First, there is a growing literature on understanding the importance of social structures for economic development (Greif, 1994, 2006). For example, Alesina and Giuliano (2014) examine the link between family ties and economic attitudes, and Bau (2016) demonstrates that kinship structure affects response to policies. Research also suggests kinship networks provide insurance (La Ferrara, 2003, Baland, Bonjean, Guirkinger and Ziparo, 2016), but may also affect incentives for investment (Baland, Guirkinger and Mali, 2011, Jakiela and Ozier, 2016). Schulz (2017) finds that cousin marriages affect democracy, and Akbari, Bahrami-Rad and Kimbrough (2016) look at the role of cousin marriage for corruption. Moscana, Nunn and Robinson (2017) find that segmentary lineages affect incidence of conflict in Africa. Lowes (2022) explores how matrilineal relative to patrilineal kinship affects outcomes for women. These papers all highlight the importance of social structures for understanding variation in development outcomes.

2. Evidence of the Importance of Age Sets from Ethnographic Data

2.1. Age Sets in General

While age sets have been well-studied in the anthropology literature, they have yet to be incorporated into economic research. In age set societies, politics is structured horizontally through groups of men of approximately the same age, who have been initiated into an age set. One of the most thoroughly studied age set societies is the Maasai of Kenya, where boys are initiated into the first age set via a circumcision ritual, after which they become warriors and live together. In their mid-twenties, when the next group of young boys is ready for initiation, the warriors transition into being farmers and husbands, officially getting married. After this, they transition into being elders who make political decisions, and finally into the oldest age set where they focused on spiritual and supernatural tasks.

One consequence of this social structure, which is well recognized in the anthropological literature, is that the presence of age sets puts natural checks on the powers of the political elite in society. Because one's age grade determines one's status in society, no one family is able to accumulate power since power cannot be passed on to one's descendants. Moreover, the fact that the system creates a cohesive group of young men that belong to the same age set provides a force that naturally checks the power of the elite, who are generally a group of elders who

belonging to a more senior age set (Gulliver, 1963, Bernardi, 1985).

An anecdote from a rural Nigerian village highlights how age sets can serve as a check on power (Bohannon, 1964). The village was divided about whether a young man named Yaav was involved in witchcraft. The youth instructed the elders of the village to convene a meeting, during which the Chief decided that Yaav should be punished for witchcraft. However, the Chief's son, whose name was Ilhugh, sided with the coalition that was against his father. When the Chief asked his son why he would side against his own father, Ilhugh replied that he and Yaav were age mates and this bond was stronger and more important. Ultimately, Yaav was spared punishment.

This story highlights a number of important consequences of age sets. First, because the age set was a unified cohesive group, they had political power. They were able to force the elders to convene a meeting, and they were able to prevent them from punishing Yaav for witchcraft. Second, it shows the strength of the horizontal ties within the community. In the end, Ilhugh's horizontal allegiance to his age mates was stronger than his vertical allegiance to his own father, despite the fact that his father was the chief. The story illustrates how age sets create a cohesive group of young able-bodied men, who are able to collectively balance the power of the political elders in the village. More generally, they are able to provide checks on any potential wrong doings or abuse of power that may occur by the elders.

2.2. Age Set initiations among the Ngbaka

The study takes place in the Sud-Ubangi province of the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC). This location is an excellent setting to examine our questions of interest. It is large, ethnically diverse, and has significant variation in age set practices, where the practice varies from one village to the next, even within the predominant ethnic group, the Ngbaka. From surveys and focus groups conducted in the area, we have learned that approximately 50% of the villages in the area traditionally have age set practices, and except in large cities, these continue to be practiced today.

Among the Ngbaka, the age set initiation ritual is called *gazawili*. This practice was documented by early ethnographers in the region. As a visual illustration of the continuity in the practice over time, Figure 1 provides images of young men from the Ngbaka tribe performing a traditional dance as part of the final stages of the age set initiation ritual. The image on the left is from the colonial period, while the image on the right is from the contemporary period,



Figure 1: Part of the age set initiation ceremony, historically (left) and today (right).

being taken by our enumerators in 2017. This is the stage of the initiation when individuals have completed their training in the forest and are reemerging into society.

We collected data from village leaders on how *gazawili* is implemented the villages of our study sample where age set rituals are practiced. These details are provided in Table 1. Generally, boys participate in the ritual around the age of 12 – though there is a lot of variation in the individual age at which individuals complete the ritual. Not all boys in the eligible age range participate. The initiation rituals are always done in groups and require several months stay in the forest in a secret location.

During the initiation, livelihood skills (like hunting, woodworking, agriculture, and witchcraft) and the history of the tribe are taught, and generally circumcisions are performed (see Table 2). The individual leading the initiation ritual tends to be a clan notable or a sage (elder) within the community. The difficult nature and the duration of the rituals naturally result in strong bonds being formed between the boys that participate in the initiation.

When asked about why participation in the ritual is important (Table 3), men from Gemena territory report that the most important reasons for participating are: to make connections with

Table 1: Age Set Initiation Details

	Mean (1)	S.D. (2)	Min. (3)	Median (4)	Max (5)	N (6)
Age generally do initiation	12.188	4.559	5.00	11.20	18.00	59
How many young men participate?						
Specially selected boys of initiation age (0/1)	0.154	0.281	0.00	0.00	1.00	59
A few boys of initiation age (0/1)	0.362	0.389	0.00	0.25	1.00	59
Some boys of initiation age (0/1)	0.445	0.423	0.00	0.50	1.00	59
All boys of initiation age (0/1)	0.039	0.184	0.00	0.00	1.00	59
Initiation Done in Group/ Individually (1/0)	1.000	0.000	1.00	1.00	1.00	59
During Initiation do the young men leave the village (0/1)	0.966	0.103	0.50	1.00	1.00	59
Where is the Initiation Done						
Secret Location in the Forest (0/1)	0.809	0.346	0.00	1.00	1.00	59
Open Location in the Forest (0/1)	0.184	0.345	0.00	0.00	1.00	59
Secret Location in the Village (0/1)	0.007	0.039	0.00	0.00	0.25	59
Open Location in the Forest (0/1)	0.000	0.000	0.00	0.00	0.00	59
Length of Initiation						
Less than a day (0/1)	0.000	0.000	0.00	0.00	0.00	59
More than one day and less than one week (0/1)	0.000	0.000	0.00	0.00	0.00	59
More than one week and less than one month (0/1)	0.050	0.180	0.00	0.00	1.00	59
More than one month and less than three months (0/1)	0.618	0.455	0.00	0.91	1.00	59
More than three months and less than six months (0/1)	0.126	0.274	0.00	0.00	1.00	59
More than six months and less than one year (0/1)	0.181	0.356	0.00	0.00	1.00	59
More than one year (0/1)	0.025	0.145	0.00	0.00	1.00	59
Circumcision performed during initiation (0/1)	0.985	0.083	0.50	1.00	1.00	59
Proportion of men who have participated in past (0: No men- 3: All Men)	1.955	0.527	0.50	2.00	3.00	59
Proportion of men who participate now (0: No - 3: All Men)	0.942	0.682	0.00	1.00	2.00	59
Do men ever refuse to participate (1: Never - 4: Often)	2.569	0.615	1.00	2.64	4.00	59
Proportion of men who participate because of pressure (0: Specific - 4: All)	1.869	0.711	1.00	2.00	3.00	59
Frequency Initiation is Administered						
Once every five years or more	0.077	0.175	0.00	0.00	1.00	59
Once every three years	0.273	0.371	0.00	0.00	1.00	59
Once a year	0.485	0.414	0.00	0.50	1.00	59
Once every six months	0.031	0.147	0.00	0.00	1.00	59
Every couple of months	0.002	0.012	0.00	0.00	0.09	59
Never	0.037	0.184	0.00	0.00	1.00	59
Doesn't Know	0.008	0.041	0.00	0.00	0.25	59
Other	0.088	0.213	0.00	0.00	1.00	59
Taught history of tribe during Initiation (0/1)	0.905	0.168	0.50	1.00	1.00	59
Teach history of clan during Initiation (0/1)	0.909	0.171	0.50	1.00	1.00	59
Must village chief complete this initiation (0/1)	0.326	0.412	0.00	0.00	1.00	59
Do men from multiple clans participate (0/1)	0.621	0.403	0.00	0.71	1.00	59
Do men from multiple villages participate (0/1)	0.543	0.400	0.00	0.60	1.00	59
Do men from multiple tribes participate (0/1)	0.251	0.371	0.00	0.00	1.00	59

Notes: This table presents village level means of responses from village leaders on initiation rituals in their village at baseline (2016).

Table 2: Skills Taught During Initiation

	Mean (1)	SD (2)	Min (3)	Median (4)	Max (5)	Obs. (6)
Which skills are learned during initiation						
Hunting (0/1)	0.840	0.260	0	1	1	59
Farming (0/1)	0.737	0.377	0	1	1	59
Communal Farming (0/1)	0.347	0.441	0	0	1	59
Public Good Maintenance (0/1)	0.332	0.436	0	0	1	59
Leadership skills (0/1)	0.316	0.446	0	0	1	59
Bokoko (0/1)	0.786	0.309	0	1	1	59
Fishing (0/1)	0.849	0.251	0	1	1	59
Sewing (0/1)	0.776	0.281	0	1	1	59
Fabrication of thatch (0/1)	0.781	0.323	0	1	1	59
Artisinal skills (0/1)	0.829	0.271	0	1	1	59
Fighting or soldiering (0/1)	0.299	0.395	0	0	1	59
Special means of communication (0/1)	0.838	0.262	0	1	1	59

Notes: This table presents village level means of responses from village leaders on initiation rituals in their village at baseline (2016).

individuals of the same age, to build work ethic, and to cultivate *bokoko*, the Lingala word for traditional religious beliefs. Reasons that are not important include: business, hiring, happiness, and money lending.

3. Baseline Data

3.1. Sample and Descriptive Statistics

Our study sample is 102 randomly selected villages from Gemena territory, which is located in the northwest of the DRC. To select the villages we first compiled a census of villages in the territory from the governor's office (where a village is defined as a collection of households managed by a village chief according to records on village chiefs compiled by territory administrators). We then randomly selected 102 villages from the territory. A map of the villages in the sample is shown in Figure 2. Of our 102 villages, 59 report having initiation rituals for young men.

The first round of data collection was in the summer of 2016. We collect basic information on various political, social, and economic characteristics of the village, as well as information on its history. We implemented tailored surveys with the Village Chief, the Sage, the Secretary, one notable from each clan of the village, the Groupement Chief (if present), and 12 randomly chosen

Table 3: Why is initiation important?

Variable	Mean (1)	S.D. (2)	Min. (3)	Median (4)	Max (5)	N (6)
How important is Initiation for the following activities: (1: Not at all Important - 5: Very Important)						
Success in life	2.681	1.036	1.00	3.00	5.00	59
Making connections with same age	3.297	1.000	1.00	3.50	5.00	59
Happiness	2.073	1.130	1.00	2.00	5.00	59
Work ethic	3.974	0.890	1.00	4.00	5.00	59
Responsibility	3.601	0.979	1.00	4.00	5.00	59
Good husband	3.181	1.215	1.00	3.00	5.00	59
Marriage	3.219	1.217	1.00	3.00	5.00	59
Learning skills	2.375	1.199	1.00	2.00	5.00	59
Bokoko	3.760	1.000	1.00	4.00	5.00	59
Business	2.136	1.308	1.00	1.50	5.00	59
Hiring	1.841	1.032	1.00	1.33	4.00	59
Money lending	1.789	0.937	1.00	1.50	4.00	59
For any other activity (0/1)	0.127	0.258	0.00	0.00	1.00	58

Notes: This table presents village level means of responses from village leaders on initiation rituals in their village at baseline (2016).

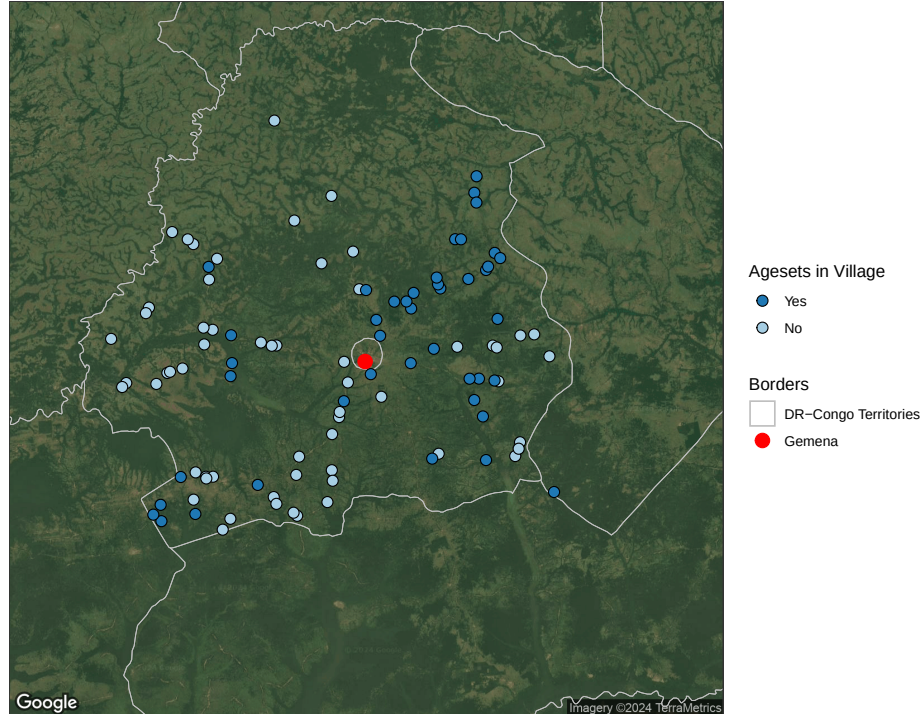


Figure 2: Location of sample villages in Gemena Territory

Table 4: Village Characteristics by Age Sets

Variable	Age Sets		No Age Sets		P-value
	Obs.	Mean	Obs.	Mean	
Number of households (2017)	59	563	43	301	0.05
Number of households (2019)	59	370	43	243	0.11
Number of households (enum estimate) (2019)	59	281	43	205	0.11
Approx. years since village was created (2019)	57	93.4	43	82	0.01
Number of clans when founded (2019)	59	2.83	43	1.98	0.01
Number of clans now (2019)	59	3.95	43	3.16	0.04
Truck access by road (0/1) (2019)	59	.915	43	.884	0.60
Road material sand (0/1) (2019)	59	.729	42	.833	0.22
Has a well (0/1) (2017)	59	.407	43	.116	0.00
Number of wells (2017)	59	1.92	43	.372	0.02
Land Titles (0/1) (2017)	59	.678	43	.698	0.83
Health center (0/1) (2017)	59	.559	43	.581	0.83
Primary School (0/1) (2017)	59	.864	43	.651	0.01
Number of primary schools (2017)	59	1.25	43	.837	0.01
Secondary School (0/1) (2017)	59	.559	43	.326	0.02
Number of secondary schools (2017)	59	.678	43	.349	0.02
Market (0/1) (2017)	59	.169	43	.093	0.27
Generator (0/1) (2017)	59	.169	43	.14	0.68
Solar panels (0/1) (2017)	59	.915	43	.907	0.89
Mobile coverage (0/1) (2017)	59	.525	43	.302	0.02
How far have to go to get good mobile coverage (km) (2017)	59	18.6	43	24.5	0.15

Notes: All means are the average characteristics of the villages using variables from baseline data (2017) and round 1 implementation data (2019). All p-values reflect the difference in means between the groups.

citizens from the village (4 old men, 4 young men, 2 old women and 2 young women). The Groupement Chief is the chief of a collection of villages; the position is generally hereditary. In choosing the random sample of villagers, we stratified by gender and age. On average 18 villagers (peasants, chief, notables, and others) were surveyed per village. The surveys were tailored to the position of each respondent, and we collected information that allows us to gain a better baseline understanding of the nature of political, social, and economic life in the villages. In total, we surveyed over 1,800 individuals from these 102 villages.

In Table 4 we present baseline characteristics of villages by those that have age set initiation rituals. Age set villages tend to be larger than those without age sets, as well as older. They also tend to have more clans represented within the village – both when the village was founded and at the time of enumeration. Age set villages are also more likely to have some types of infrastructure – such as well and access to mobile phone coverage.

We also present information on the village chiefs at the time of the baseline data collection in Table 5. The chiefs tend to look pretty similar across those villages that have age sets and those that do not. Chiefs across both types of villages are around 50 years old and have about 7 years of education. The average age at which individual first become chief is 40 years old.

Table 5: Chief Characteristics by Age Sets

Variable	Age Sets	No Age Sets	P-value
Chiefs in 2017			
Age	51.9	49	0.16
Education Years	7.23	7.14	0.89
Not in the village often = 1	.386	.372	0.89
Start Age	40.5	40.3	0.95
Elected chief (elected by villagers)	.772	.767	0.96
Wealth based on appearance (1/5)	1.84	1.77	0.59
Wealth above villager's median wealth (0/1)	.333	.209	0.17
Obs.	59	43	

Notes: All means are the average characteristics of the village chiefs. All p-values reflect the difference in means between the groups.

Finally, we also present information on our baseline sample of villagers in Table 6. Villagers look fairly similar across age set and non-age set villages. However, villagers in age set villages are more likely to be Catholic and report higher trust in the chief.

Table 6: Villager Characteristics by Age Sets

Variable	Age Sets		No Age Sets		P-value
	Mean	Obs.	Mean	Obs.	
Age	708	39.4	517	39.3	0.77
Married	708	.849	517	.868	0.16
Years of education	708	6.79	517	6.59	0.35
Catholic (0/1)	708	.453	517	.354	0.06
Protestant (0/1)	708	.511	517	.59	0.13
Pentecostal (0/1)	708	.0254	517	.0387	0.28
Respondent wealth based on appearance (1–5)	707	1.62	516	1.63	0.90
Trust in chief (1–4)	704	3.35	515	3.2	0.09
Satisfaction with chief's performance	699	3.99	515	3.91	0.52

Notes: The table presents the average characteristics of villagers in the 2016 baseline survey administered in Gemena territory.

3.2. Age sets and Political Authority

Using our baseline data, we can explore how the presence of age sets is correlated with different views on politics, accountability, and norms of gerontocracy. Individuals respond to a series of questions that describe both how they believe decisions should be made and also how decisions

Table 7: Baseline Survey: Age sets & Political Authority

	Dependent Variable:			
	<i>Elders Should be Responsible for Decisions</i>	<i>Relative Power Elders vs. Young</i>	<i>Chief Support from Elders vs. Young</i>	<i>Trust in Elders</i>
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Age Set	0.484*** (0.147)	0.411** (0.168)	-0.174*** (0.064)	-0.105** (0.048)
Observations	1,222	1,201	1,205	1,207
Villages	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	2.98	3.09	2.95	-0.11

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the village level. Regressions control for respondents age, age squared, and sex. *Ageset* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if the respondent originates from a village that has agesets according to village notables and the village sage. The dependent variables are defined as follows. *Elders Should be Responsible for Decisions* measures whether respondents believe that older persons should be responsible for making decisions in the village on a scale from 1 to 5, ranging from strongly disagree to strongly agree. *Elders Deserve Respect* measures respondents' perceptions of the respect accorded to older individuals on a scale from 1 to 5, ranging from strongly disagree to strongly agree. *Relative Power Elders vs. Young* is an index of the perceived power differential between older and younger members on a scale from 1 to 5, ranging from young men have a lot more political power to elder men have a lot more political power. *Chief Support from Elders vs. Youth* is a categorical indicator assessing whether village chiefs receive relatively more support from older persons relative to younger ones. *Trust in Elders* measures the level of trust in older individuals on a 1 to 4 scale, ranging from no trust to complete trust. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

are made in their respective communities. These results are presented in Table 7. First, in column (1), individuals from villages with age sets are more likely to report that elders should be responsible for decision making. Additionally, in columns (2) and (3), they report that actual political authority is allocated in this way in their village – elders tend to hold more political power and chiefs get more support from the elders than the young. However, individuals in age set communities are less likely to trust elders – those who hold political power. We also explore how these beliefs and description of practices vary by the age and gender of the respondents. These views seem to be fairly consistent across sub-groups of respondents. However, female villagers are less likely to say that the chief gets more support from elders relative to the young.

4. Experimental Design

We now describe the experimental design and implementation. We partnered with a local NGO, Congo Helping Hands (CHH), a non-profit organization that has worked in the DRC since 2004, for the design and implementation of the project.¹ The project provides the village chief with a cash grant for the purchase of health products. These health products are over-the-counter

¹The founders of CHH have been working in the DRC since 1998. CHH projects aim improve the quality of life of Congolese people through human development in health, education, agriculture, and microeconomics. CHH has conducted many projects related to water, sanitation and hygiene (commonly referred to as WASH) throughout the DRC.

products that are generally difficult to access in rural parts of DRC, but that have been shown to be effective for improving health. The three products are: deworming pills (mbendazole), chlorine tablets (Aquatabs) that can be used to chlorinate drinking water, and oral rehydration salts (ORS) that can be used for rehydration when sick with diarrhea. To address access concerns, these products are sold by CHH vendors who visit the villages to sell the products at a subsidized rate.

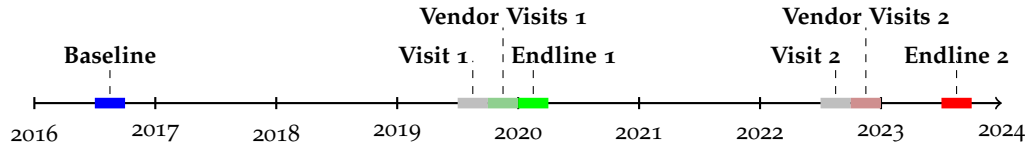
As is standard in such projects, CHH formed a small committee with six villagers, referred to as village development committees (VDCs), to help administer the project. The committee members' responsibilities are: to ensure that the chief uses the funds appropriately, to ensure the products are distributed in a fair and equitable manner, to help to distribute products themselves, to help villagers to use them, and to answer any questions that may arise. Because the positions are typically volunteer positions, the committee members are not paid.

The primary experimental manipulation in this project is in how committee members are selected. For this project, CHH formed the committees in a manner that is more structured than is typical for them, so that we can analyze the effects of different types of committees and how this varies depending on whether a village has age sets. For a random selection of 50% of the villages, CHH created committees that are only men between the ages of 18 and 35 (*Young Male Committee*). In the other 50% of villages, committees were diverse, reflecting the composition of those who are interested in volunteering for the committee (*Diverse Committee*). In both sets of villages, the committee members are chosen randomly (or randomly conditional on the criteria) among those who volunteered to be a part of the committee. This adjustment to the NGO's standard practice provides us with the variation in committee composition that allows us to observe whether the success of the project depends on the age and gender of committee members and whether this differs depending on whether the village traditionally has age sets or not.

4.1. Project Structure and Timeline

The project implementation involved several steps. After the baseline survey, CHH visited the villages to implement the project. This included meeting with the villagers to describe the project, forming the village development committees, and delivering the cash grant. Project vendors would then visit the villages to sell the health products. Finally, an endline survey was conducted with villagers, the committee members, and chiefs. Two rounds of the project were implemented,

Figure 3: Project Timeline



Notes: The figure shows the project timeline, including the baseline data collection and the two rounds of the project. Each project rounds includes an baseline visit, three vendor visits, and an endline visit.

Figure 4: Implementation of Village Meetings



Notes: The photos are from two village meetings. Both photos are from the initial visit and were taken by CHH staff. The photo on the left is from the initial information meeting. The photo on the right is from the meeting for individuals interested in volunteering to be on a village oversight committee.

i.e. two rounds of delivering the cash grant and selling health products. See figure 3 for the project timeline. Below we describe each step of implementation in greater detail.

1. Baseline Survey. During this visit, baseline data are collected. A relationship with the chief is established. This occurred during June 2016 to September 2016 for Gemena territory.

2. Implementation Visits. The implementation visit involved several types of meetings, First, CHH held a meeting with villagers to explain the project, the distribution of funds to the chief, the creation of a Village Development Committee (VDC) to oversee the chief, and the use of the health products.

Second, a meeting was held for those interested in becoming volunteers for the VDC to review the role and responsibilities of the committee members. From those who attend this meeting and report interested in being on the committee, we randomly select individuals. As described above, in half of villages, CHH forms committees by randomly selecting individuals among those who are interested in being volunteers. In the other half of randomly selected villages, CHH forms

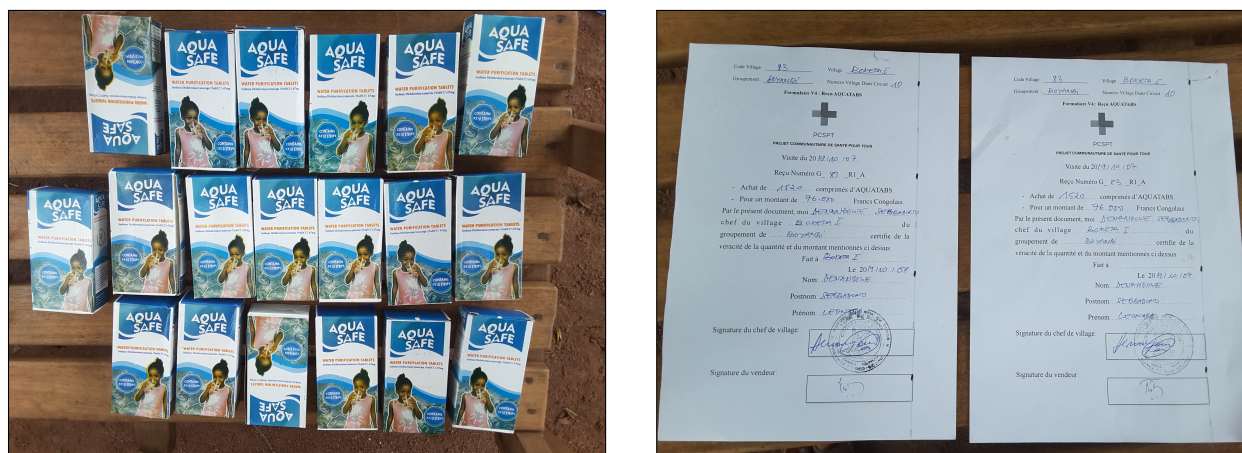
committees that comprise only young men (between 18 and 35 years old), who are randomly selected from those who volunteer to be on the committee. We survey all individuals who attend the committee information meeting, regardless of the treatment status of the village to collect basic demographic information.

Once the committee has been selected and committee members have been notified, CHH meets with the committee alone, with the chief alone, and then with the committee and chief together. During these meetings, CHH again explains the set up of the program. Specifically, CHH explains that the chief will receive a cash grant, that the cash grant is only for the purchase of health products from the project vendors, and that project vendors will visit the village in several weeks time to sell the health products at a subsidized price. The chief is responsible for using the funds to purchase the product and for distributing the products. The committee is responsible for overseeing the performance of the chief, for assisting with product distribution. Both the chief and the committee are responsible for communicating with each other and with villagers. Finally, at the end of the visit, CHH provides the chief with the \$100 grant (in Congolese Francs) for the purchase of health products.

3. Vendor Visits. CHH hired and trained vendors that would visit the villages. After approximately 3 weeks, the first vendor visits the village. Vendor visits are staggered so that only one vendor visits each week. One vendor sells deworming pills, one vendor sells Aquatabs, and another vendor sells ORS. A vendor for each product visits every village at least once. The vendors provide access to the three health products and sell the products at highly discounted prices (50% discount) to the village chief, who can use the grant provided by CHH to purchase these products for the members of the village.

4. Endline Survey. Several months after the last vendor visit, the enumerators visit the village again. The endline for round 1 was conducted in 2019/2020 (prior to Covid-19); the endline for round 2 was conducted in 2023. Endline survey data was collected from: the committee members, the chief, and randomly selected households. The survey with the committee members and chief asks about the meetings that were held and whether there were any disagreements or problems in the implementation of the program. The surveys with the households asks about the members health experiences since the implementation of the project, access to the health products, and views on the performance of the chief and village committee. Finally, after the completion of the endline surveys, the enumerators ask the chief to return any unused project funds.

Figure 5: Vendor Visit Implementation



Notes: The photos are from a vendor visit to a village. The photos were taken by the CHH's vendor of Aquatabs during one sale. At the end of each sale the vendor is asked to take a picture of the amount of products sold (left photo) and of the two receipts (right photo). One receipt goes to the chief and one receipt is kept for the CHH's records.

5. Network Survey. As part of the 2023 endline, we also collected network data following the methodology proposed by [Breza, Chandrasekhar, Lubold, McCormick and Pan \(2023\)](#). We collect network data only from male respondents. Villagers, committee members, and the chief complete this portion of the survey. The network survey elicits the list of individuals within the village with whom the respondent socializes, borrows or lends, asks advice, and discuss politics. The survey then collects detailed data on the friends of the respondents, such as their clan, whether they did the age set initiation together, and whether their friends are committee members, the village chief, or notables within the community.

4.2. Validating Implementation

We find that in all 102 villages, the CHH project was well-received by the villagers and the village meetings were well attended. Figure 4 presents photos from two meetings. Table 8 reports statistics on average participation in the villages. Average total attendance during the implementation meetings was just under 100 individuals. The mean was slightly higher in non-age set villages (110 versus 87). The average attendance during the committee selection meeting was 50 individuals, and this was also slightly higher in non-age set villages (54 versus 48). Overall, we find that the number of individuals from each gender by age category group is pretty similar across the categories.

We also examine whether the committees were formed in accordance with the treatment status

Table 8: Villager Participation in CHH Meetings

	All Villages					Age Set Villages					No Age Set Villages				
	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Village Meeting Attendance Round 1	102	96.696	45.187	36	343	59	86.814	31.936	36	160	43	110.256	56.360	36	343
Village Meeting Attendance Round 2	102	58.961	43.215	11	308	59	51.186	32.091	11	203	43	69.628	53.548	18	308
Committee Meeting Attendance	97	58.258	20.665	29	142	55	54.182	17.443	29	110	42	63.595	23.403	33	142
Committee Meeting - Surveyed	98	50.133	17.599	17	110	56	47.143	15.376	26	110	42	54.119	19.676	17	99
Young Men less than or equal to 35 years old	98	13.378	5.638	3	30	56	12.446	4.928	3	29	42	14.619	6.313	4	30
Young Women less than or equal to 35 years old	98	8.500	4.568	1	27	56	8.357	4.769	1	27	42	8.690	4.336	1	19
Old Men more than 35 years old	98	18.643	7.908	4	49	56	17.750	6.487	6	36	42	19.833	9.432	4	49
Old Women more than 35 years old	99	9.515	5.985	0	31	56	8.589	5.656	1	31	43	10.721	6.250	0	28

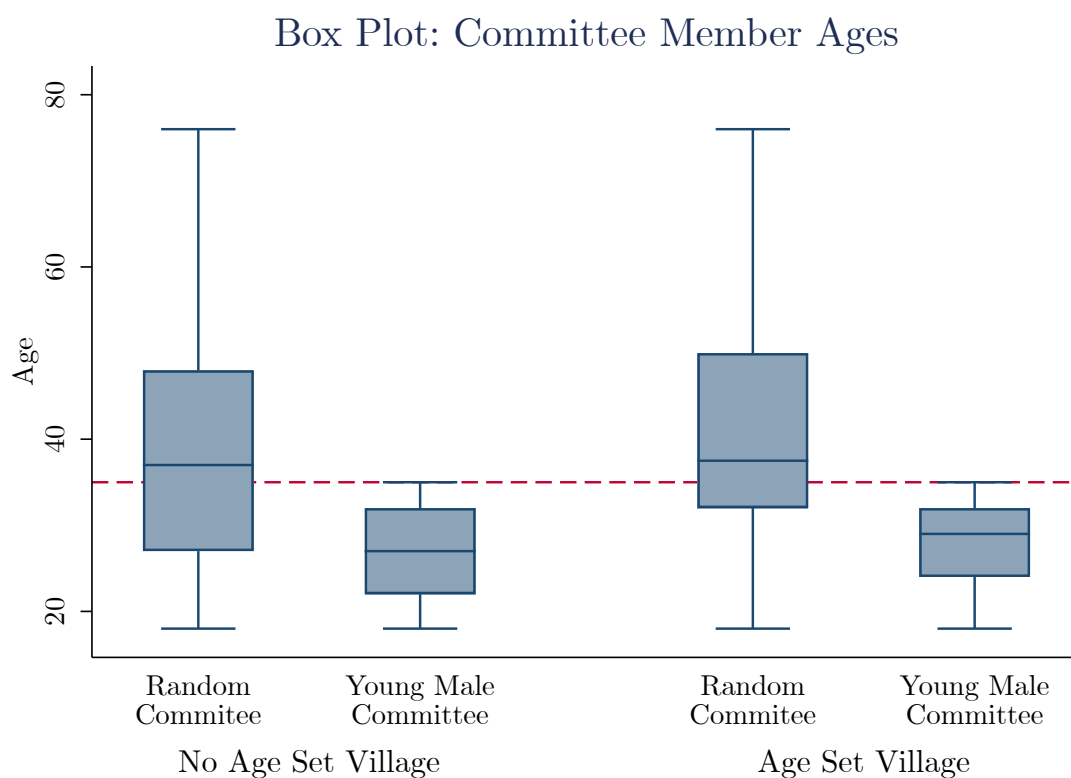
Notes: The table displays the number of participants in the two main meetings held by CHH in each village. Statistics are provided for the full sample (*All Villages*), villages where age set rituals are practiced (*Age Set Villages*), and villages where age set rituals are not practiced (*No Age Set Villages*). *Village Meeting Attendance Round 1* and *Village Meeting Attendance Round 2* are the total audience members for the village's meetings held on the second day of implementation. The meeting in round 1 was held in 2019; the meeting in round 2 in 2022. *Committee Meeting Attendance* is the total audience at the *Committee Selection Meeting*. *Committee Meeting - Surveyed* collects demographic information on those who attend the *Committee Selection Meeting* and is used to produce summary statistics on men and women older or younger than 35 years old who attended the meeting.

– i.e. only including young men or a diverse committee. Figure 6 reports information on the age distribution of the selected committee members by treatment status and whether or not their village was an age set village. The figure suggests that the manipulation of the age composition of committees was successful. Young male committees are on average much younger than the random committees. Note, in one village assigned to receive a young male committee, a man of 53 years old got selected to be on the committee because there were not enough young men who volunteered. Figure 7 provides information on the gender break down. In all but one case, where the number of necessary volunteers was low, the young male committees are comprised of just men. Note, two women were selected as committee members in the young male committee treatment because only four men below the age of 35 volunteered at the committee selection meeting in one village.

Finally, Table 9 presents summary statistics of the committee member characteristics by treatment group. As expected, in the young male committee treatment groups (columns 2 and 4), almost all committee members are male. In the diverse committees, between 64 and 71 percent of the committee members are male. Among the young male committees, the average age is also much lower – between 28.9 years and 30.8 years relative to 40 years. Another significant difference across the committee types is that the members of the young committees tend to be better educated. Additionally, in age set villages, committee members report feeling closer to the chief.

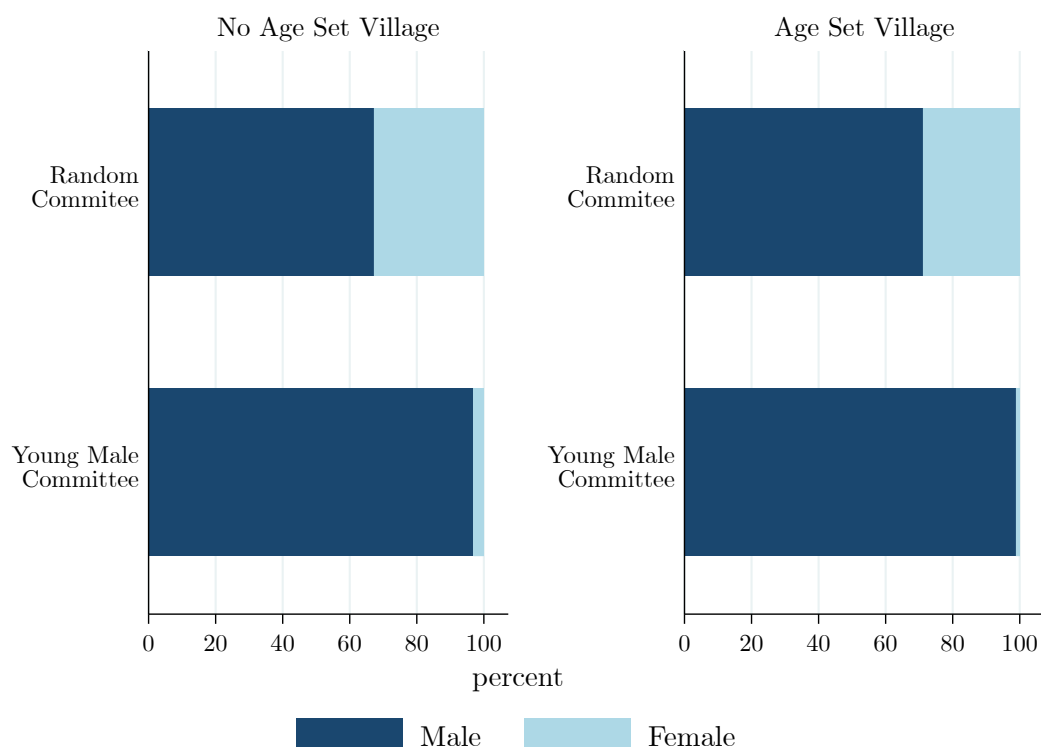
Finally, when the committee composition was reported to the chief, our enumerators were asked to record how satisfied the chief appeared. When notifying the chief of the list of selected committee members the enumerator is instructed to “Pay attention to how the chief reacts to the list of selected volunteers”. The enumerator is then asked “Did the chief seem completely

Figure 6: Age of the selected committee members by treatment status and age set practices



Notes: The figure displays the age composition of the committees by treatment status and age set practices. The left part of the plot presents the age composition for villages where age sets are not practiced (*No Age Set Village*). The right hand side of the plot presents the result for villages where age sets are practiced (*Age Set Village*). Within each category of villages *Random Committee* stands for committees selected randomly among all volunteers. *Committee Young* are committees made only of young male volunteers.

Figure 7: Gender composition of the committees by treatment status and Age set practices.



Notes: The left panel of the figure presents the gender composition of committees for villages without age sets (*No Age Set Village*). The right panel of the figure presents the result for villages with age sets (*Age Set Village*). The top panel presents the gender composition for villages assigned to the random selection of committee members (*Random Committee*), and the bottom panel presents the gender composition for villages assigned to young male committees (*Young Male Committee*).

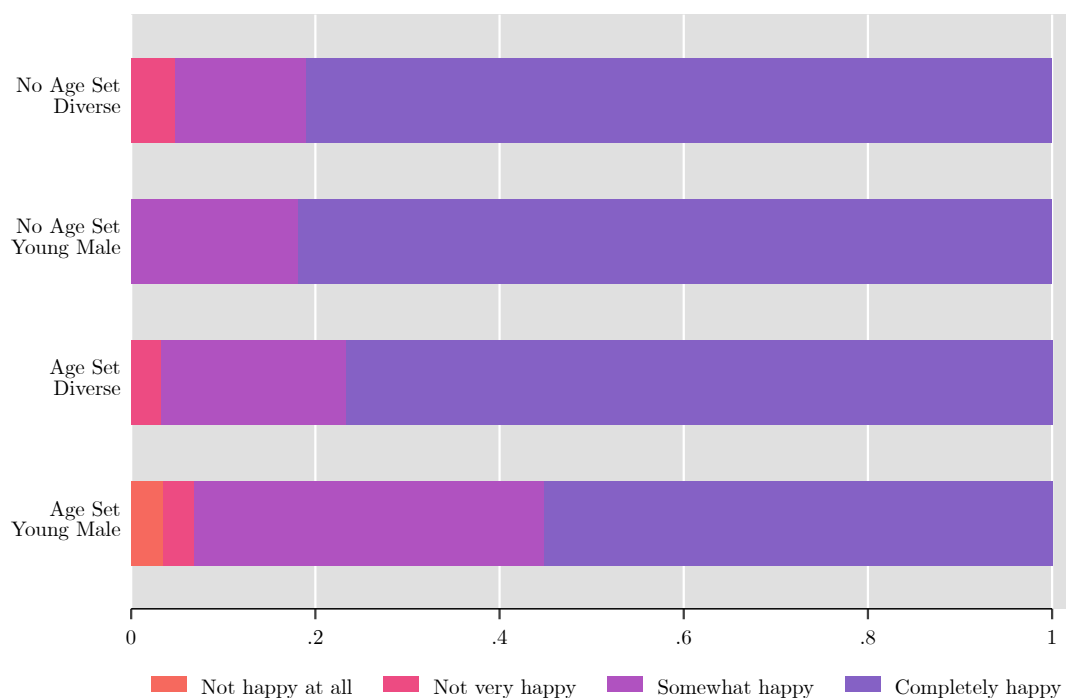
Table 9: Committee Members Characteristics by Treatment Group

	No Age Set Diverse		No Age Set Young		Age Set Diverse		Age Set Young	
	Mean	Obs.	Mean	P-value	Mean	P-value	Mean	P-value
Male	115	.643	123	.967	0.00	170	.706	0.36
Age	115	40.4	123	28.9	0.00	170	41.8	0.39
Married	115	.843	123	.878	0.47	169	.876	0.40
Number of children 0 to 5	115	3.05	123	2.69	0.25	170	2.6	0.15
Number of children 6 to 17	115	3.17	123	2.67	0.11	170	3.58	0.21
Number of adults	115	4.17	123	3.85	0.19	170	4.15	0.94
Years of education	115	6.43	123	8	0.01	170	6.54	0.84
Catholic (0/1)	115	.322	123	.374	0.62	169	.456	0.14
Protestant (0/1)	115	.557	123	.553	0.97	169	.533	0.79
Petecostal (0/1)	115	.104	123	.065	0.43	169	.00592	0.03
Notable (0/1)	115	.0348	123	.0569	0.35	170	.0529	0.46
Wealth (1/5)	115	1.5	123	1.59	0.50	169	1.6	0.40
Closeness to chief (0/5)	115	3.22	123	3.37	0.43	168	3.76	0.00
Chief satisfaction with committee (0 to 4)	21	3.76	22	3.82	0.70	30	3.73	0.85

Notes: All means are the average characteristics of the committee members using Round 1 of implementation data (2019), when the committees are first constructed. All p-values are clustered at the village level and reflect the difference in means between the control group (No Age Sets and Diverse Committee) and the other groups.

satisfied, somewhat satisfied, not very satisfied, or not satisfied at all with the list of chosen volunteers?”. The distribution of responses are reported in Figure 8. We find that when the committee was comprised of young men, the chief was less satisfied with the composition of the committee. The average satisfaction of the chief is lowest for the age set villages assigned to the young male committees.

Figure 8: The chief's reaction to the selected committee members.



Notes: This figure presents the chief's satisfaction with the committee when it is formed in 2019. Chief's were presented with the selected committee members; enumerators were asked to observe how satisfied they thought the chief was with the selected committee members, where (1) is not at all satisfied and (4) is very satisfied.

5. Empirical Strategy

For the village level analysis, our baseline estimating equation takes the following form:

$$y_v = \beta_1 \mathbb{1}_v^{Young\ Male\ Committee} + \beta_2 \mathbb{1}_v^{Age\ Set} + \beta_3 \mathbb{1}_v^{Age\ Set} \times \mathbb{1}_v^{Young\ Male\ Committee} + \mathbf{X}'_v \boldsymbol{\Phi} + \delta_r + \varepsilon_v, \quad (1)$$

where v indexes villages and the sample comprises our randomly chosen villages from Gemena territory. The variable $\mathbb{1}_i^{Age\ Set}$ is an indicator that equals one if the village traditionally had age sets. The variable $\mathbb{1}_v^{Young\ Male\ Committee}$ is an indicator that equals one if village v was randomly chosen to have a village committee that comprises only young men, where young is age 18 to 35. Because two rounds of the project were implemented, we include round fixed effects, δ_r . This means there are two observations per village. Standard errors are clustered at the village level for the village-level analysis. $\mathbf{X}'_v$ denotes a vector of control variables, including distance to Gemena, the major urban area, and the estimated number of households in the village at baseline. For the individual level outcomes (e.g, for our random sample of villagers), we estimate an equation analogous to equation (1) but at the individual level and with an additional vector of individual level covariates that includes respondent age, age squared, and gender.

The variable y_v denotes our outcomes of interest. These outcomes include various proxies for the functioning of the project including: tasks performed by committee members and chiefs; project money that is unaccounted for (i.e. not spent on health products or returned to the project at the end of the round); distribution of health products; health outcomes.

We are interested in all coefficients in equation (1). The sign of β_2 tells us whether villages with age sets have more or less successful projects, based on our measures, when the committee is diverse. The sign of β_1 tells us whether villages with committees that comprise young men have more or less successful projects, based on our measures, when the village does not have age set practices. β_3 tells us whether there is a differential effect of young male committees in villages that have age sets.

5.1. Baseline Balance

We present balance on baseline characteristics at the village and chief level in Tables 10 and 11. We find that chiefs are fairly similar across our treatment groups. We do find that age set villages have different characteristics – for example, they tend to be older and have more clans.

Table 10: Chiefs Characteristics by Treatment Group

	No Age Set Diverse		No Age Set Young			Age Set Diverse			Age Set Young		
	Mean	Obs.	Mean	P-value	Obs.	Mean	P-value	Obs.	Mean	P-value	Obs.
Male	1.000	1.000	.	22	21	1.000	.	28	1.000	.	30
Age	50.952	47.091	0.240	22	21	53.107	0.358	28	50.400	0.841	30
Married	1.000	1.000	.	22	21	1.000	.	28	1.000	.	30
Years of education	8.048	8.091	0.970	22	21	8.107	0.953	28	8.467	0.669	30
Catholic (0/1)	0.476	0.318	0.295	22	21	0.286	0.172	28	0.400	0.595	30
Protestant (0/1)	0.429	0.636	0.173	22	21	0.714	0.039	28	0.533	0.468	30
Petecostal (0/1)	0.048	0.045	0.974	22	21	0.000	0.247	28	0.067	0.780	30
Notable (0/1)	0.048	0.045	0.974	22	21	0.143	0.280	28	0.033	0.800	30
Wealth based on appearance (1/5)	1.762	1.773	0.957	22	21	1.679	0.672	28	2.000	0.173	29
Wealth index	0.035	0.009	0.932	22	20	-0.035	0.789	28	0.672	0.247	30
Chief's wealth above villagers' median (0/1)	0.333	0.091	0.046	22	21	0.321	0.931	28	0.367	0.810	30

Notes: All means are the average characteristics of the chiefs using baseline data (2016). All p-values reflect the difference in means between the control group (No Age Sets and Diverse Committee) and the other groups.

Table 11: Village Characteristics by Treatment Group

	No Age Set Diverse		No Age Set Young			Age Set Diverse			Age Set Young		
	Mean	Obs.	Mean	P-value	Obs.	Mean	P-value	Obs.	Mean	P-value	Obs.
Number of households (2017)	336.571	21	267.136	0.296	22	693.733	0.127	30	427.172	0.487	29
Number of households (2019)	350.905	21	139.545	0.023	22	389.067	0.738	30	350.034	0.995	29
Number of households (enum estimate) (2019)	277.524	21	135.455	0.023	22	306.600	0.711	30	255.310	0.757	29
Approx. years since village was created (2019)	83.905	21	80.136	0.641	22	95.967	0.057	30	90.519	0.317	27
Number of clans when founded (2019)	2.048	21	1.909	0.768	22	3.000	0.092	30	2.655	0.172	29
Number of clans now (2019)	3.238	21	3.091	0.798	22	4.467	0.046	30	3.414	0.708	29
More than one tribe (0/1)(2017)	0.714	21	0.455	0.081	22	0.867	0.178	30	0.793	0.526	29
Truck access by road (0/1) (2019)	0.952	21	0.818	0.171	22	0.900	0.500	30	0.931	0.758	29
Road material sand (0/1) (2019)	0.750	20	0.909	0.168	22	0.733	0.897	30	0.724	0.843	29
Has a well (0/1) (2017)	0.143	21	0.091	0.603	22	0.333	0.123	30	0.483	0.009	29
Number of wells (2017)	0.429	21	0.318	0.752	22	0.867	0.322	30	3.000	0.035	29
Land Titles (0/1) (2017)	0.714	21	0.682	0.821	22	0.667	0.723	30	0.690	0.854	29
Health center (0/1) (2017)	0.524	21	0.636	0.462	22	0.600	0.595	30	0.517	0.964	29
Primary School (0/1) (2017)	0.762	21	0.545	0.136	22	0.833	0.534	30	0.897	0.202	29
Number of primary schools (2017)	1.048	21	0.636	0.054	22	1.333	0.264	30	1.172	0.547	29
Secondary School (0/1) (2017)	0.381	21	0.273	0.457	22	0.633	0.072	30	0.483	0.481	29
Number of secondary schools (2017)	0.429	21	0.273	0.335	22	0.700	0.110	30	0.655	0.330	29
Market (0/1) (2017)	0.048	21	0.136	0.322	22	0.200	0.118	30	0.138	0.298	29
Generator (0/1) (2017)	0.190	21	0.091	0.353	22	0.133	0.587	30	0.207	0.888	29
Solar panels (0/1) (2017)	0.952	21	0.864	0.322	22	0.933	0.780	30	0.897	0.479	29
Mobile coverage (0/1) (2017)	0.429	21	0.182	0.074	22	0.567	0.337	30	0.483	0.710	29
How far for good mobile coverage (km) (2017)	32.615	13	31.500	0.876	20	31.412	0.867	17	29.789	0.645	19

Notes: All means are the average characteristics of the villages using variables from baseline data (2016) and round 1 implementation data (2019). All p-values reflect the difference in means between the groups.

6. Effects on Committee Performance

6.1. Tasks Performed by Committee Members

We examine various measures of committee performance. First, we examine the types of project tasks performed by committee members. These tasks include organizing meetings, organizing product distribution, distributing products, meeting with villagers, meeting with the chief, and keeping records. We construct an index of all of these tasks, which is the sum of each task a committee member reports doing.

These results are presented in Columns 1 and 2 of Table 12. We find evidence that young male committees in villages with age sets engage in more overall tasks for the project. We can also look at different types of tasks that committee members complete in Table 13. Specifically, young male committees in age set villages are more likely to organize a meeting, organize product distribution, distribute products, and hold meetings with the villagers. They are no more likely to keep records or hold meetings with the chief.

6.2. Committee Member Closeness

We also ask committee members how close they feel to each other, the chiefs, and to villagers. These results are presented in Table 14. Young Male Committees in age set villages report feeling closer to each other (columns 1 and 2) and to villagers (columns 5 and 6). Interestingly, and as was present in the summary statistics, committee members also report feeling closer to chiefs in age set villages, but this is not differential by committee type.

7. Effects on Chief Behavior

7.1. Oversight Tasks Performed by Chiefs

We also explore the effects of treatment on the tasks that chiefs perform. These is presented in columns 3 and 4 of Table 12. In this overall index we find no evidence that chiefs perform more project tasks in age set villages when there is a young male committee. As we did for committee members, we can also examine effects by the type of task in Table 15. We find evidence that chiefs in age set villages with young male committees report having more meetings. Interesting, we find evidence they are less likely to organize product distribution and less likely to distribute

Table 12: Oversight Tasks Performed by Committee Members and Chiefs

	<i>Dep. Var.: Committee and Chief tasks</i>			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	<i>Task index [0-6]</i>			
	<i>Committee Members</i>		<i>Chiefs</i>	
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.772** (0.295)	0.696** (0.292)	0.261 (0.398)	0.316 (0.377)
Age Set	−0.028 (0.216)	0.002 (0.207)	0.109 (0.309)	0.205 (0.294)
Young Male Committee	−0.257 (0.257)	−0.150 (0.260)	−0.216 (0.310)	−0.328 (0.284)
Observations	1,110	1,110	202	202
Villages	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	3.068	3.068	4.411	4.411
Total effect	0.488	0.548	0.154	0.193
SE	0.208	0.202	0.335	0.309
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Committee Tasks Index* is the sum of indicators for each committee task's indicator (organize meeting, organize distribution, distribute products, meet peasants, meet committee and keep records) and it takes values [0-6]. *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set* × *Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 13: Oversight Tasks Performed by Committee Members

	<i>Dep. Var.: Committee tasks</i>					
	(1) <i>Organize meeting [0/1]</i>	(2)	(3) <i>Organize distribution [0/1]</i>	(4)	(5) <i>Distribute products [0/1]</i>	(6)
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.155** (0.061)	0.157** (0.062)	0.194* (0.103)	0.165 (0.102)	0.241** (0.110)	0.213* (0.110)
Age Set	0.013 (0.040)	0.022 (0.040)	0.019 (0.073)	0.048 (0.074)	0.028 (0.081)	0.049 (0.080)
Young Male Committee	-0.045 (0.041)	-0.049 (0.042)	-0.090 (0.086)	-0.055 (0.087)	-0.159 (0.097)	-0.123 (0.099)
Observations	1,110	1,110	1,110	1,110	1,110	1,110
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.150	0.150	0.595	0.595	0.748	0.748
Total effect	0.123	0.129	0.123	0.158	0.110	0.139
SE	0.053	0.052	0.076	0.077	0.073	0.073
	<i>Meet peasants [0/1]</i>		<i>Meet chief [0/1]</i>		<i>Keep records [0/1]</i>	
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.114* (0.062)	0.108* (0.062)	0.036 (0.070)	0.025 (0.070)	0.032 (0.093)	0.028 (0.094)
Age Set	-0.001 (0.047)	-0.010 (0.047)	0.001 (0.053)	-0.009 (0.055)	-0.087 (0.067)	-0.097 (0.068)
Young Male Committee	-0.011 (0.049)	0.001 (0.049)	0.040 (0.055)	0.059 (0.056)	0.007 (0.071)	0.016 (0.071)
Observations	1,110	1,110	1,110	1,110	1,110	1,110
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.529	0.529	0.595	0.595	0.452	0.452
Total effect	0.103	0.099	0.077	0.075	-0.048	-0.053
SE	0.043	0.043	0.056	0.058	0.066	0.066
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 14: Committee member closeness to other committee members, chief, and villagers

	<i>Dep. Var.: Committee member closeness to [...]:</i>					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	<i>Other committee members [0-5]</i>		<i>Chief [0-5]</i>		<i>Villagers [0-5]</i>	
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.234** (0.099)	0.245** (0.096)	0.037 (0.150)	0.046 (0.152)	0.178* (0.105)	0.202** (0.102)
Age Set	-0.123 (0.076)	-0.101 (0.072)	0.300*** (0.096)	0.292*** (0.101)	-0.055 (0.081)	-0.053 (0.078)
Young Male Committee	-0.012 (0.077)	-0.035 (0.074)	0.058 (0.127)	0.045 (0.128)	-0.067 (0.081)	-0.104 (0.078)
Observations	1,108	1,108	1,111	1,111	1,111	1,111
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	3.918	3.918	3.680	3.680	3.701	3.701
Total Effect	.099	.109	.394	.383	.055	.046
SE	.075	.074	.09	.093	.079	.075
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Village Controls* include: Estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets (baseline measure). *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Standard errors are clustered at the village level. Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

products (though this coefficient is not significant). We find no significant differential effects for the other project tasks.

Finally, we also ask if the share of money missing at the village level predicts what villagers guess about the money missing. We find a positive and significant relationship between how much money is actually missing and what villagers think is missing.

Table 15: Tasks Performed by Chiefs

	<i>Dep. Var.: Chief tasks</i>					
	(1) <i>Organize meeting [0/1]</i>	(2) <i>Organize meeting [0/1]</i>	(3) <i>Organize distribution [0/1]</i>	(4) <i>Organize distribution [0/1]</i>	(5) <i>Distribute products [0/1]</i>	(6) <i>Distribute products [0/1]</i>
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.307** (0.138)	0.317** (0.137)	-0.058* (0.034)	-0.051* (0.029)	-0.119 (0.134)	-0.079 (0.131)
Age Set	-0.046 (0.101)	-0.014 (0.096)	0.024 (0.024)	0.023 (0.021)	0.019 (0.102)	0.037 (0.105)
Young Male Committee	-0.146 (0.101)	-0.171* (0.100)	0.023 (0.023)	0.014 (0.019)	0.098 (0.100)	0.032 (0.099)
Observations	202	202	202	202	202	202
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.322	0.322	0.985	0.985	0.787	0.787
Total effect	0.115	0.133	-0.011	-0.015	-0.003	-0.010
SE	0.107	0.100	0.034	0.031	0.103	0.103
	<i>Meet peasants [0/1]</i>		<i>Meet committee [0/1]</i>		<i>Keep records [0/1]</i>	
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.090 (0.142)	0.051 (0.140)	0.077 (0.136)	0.103 (0.132)	-0.036 (0.056)	-0.024 (0.053)
Age Set	0.024 (0.103)	0.056 (0.100)	0.058 (0.096)	0.072 (0.095)	0.031 (0.037)	0.031 (0.037)
Young Male Committee	-0.129 (0.112)	-0.081 (0.114)	-0.063 (0.109)	-0.106 (0.106)	0.001 (0.045)	-0.017 (0.040)
Observations	202	202	202	202	202	202
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.594	0.594	0.762	0.762	0.960	0.960
Total effect	-0.016	0.025	0.072	0.069	-0.004	-0.010
SE	0.104	0.105	0.102	0.097	0.043	0.041
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 16: Villager Guess of Money Missing and Actual Money Missing

	<i>Dep. Var.: Share Money Missing Guessed</i>				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	<i>Share Money Missing Guessed</i>				
Share Money Missing	0.264*** (0.071)	0.260*** (0.071)	0.253*** (0.075)	0.250*** (0.075)	0.274*** (0.073)
Age Set × Young Male Committee					-0.026 (0.028)
Age Set					0.042* (0.023)
Young Male Committee					0.000 (0.016)
Observations	1,625	1,625	1,625	1,625	1,625
Villages	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.069	0.069	0.069	0.069	0.069
SE	0.176	0.176	0.176	0.176	0.176
Village Controls	N	N	Y	Y	N
Individual Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N
Age Set and Young Male Controls	N	N	N	N	Y

Notes: Village Controls include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. Individual Controls include: an indicator variable equal to 1 if villager is a male, age, and age squared. Age Set is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets. Young Male Committee is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

7.2. Money Missing and Health Product Purchase

Table 17 presents the results of our equation 1, where the outcomes are share of money missing and amount of money missing. We find no evidence of significant differences across treatment groups.

We also look at how the money is spent across the various health products in Table 18. Age set villages spend slightly more on deworming pills. Otherwise, we find little evidence of significant differences in allocation choices across treatment arms.

In summary, we find evidence that tailoring the intervention to the local context seems to have improved how committees function. Young male committees in age set villages perform more tasks and feel closer to each other. This does not crowd out chief effort – though chiefs are less likely to be involved in product distribution in age set villages with young male committees. However, tailoring the intervention to the local context did not effect overall efficiency in the sense it did not reduce the amount of money missing – which was overall quite low. Given no effects on efficiency, we now turn to the distributional consequences of the intervention

Table 17: Money missing (share and amount)

	<i>Dep. Var.: Money missing (share and amount)</i>			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	<i>Share money missing [0/1]</i>		<i>Money missing (CF) [0-165,000]</i>	
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.02 (0.05)	0.02 (0.05)	3278.47 (7984.88)	3303.90 (7941.84)
Age Set	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.03)	-3376.43 (4759.54)	-4263.32 (4955.23)
Young Male Committee	0.01 (0.04)	0.02 (0.04)	2255.84 (6608.77)	2483.88 (6407.06)
Observations	204	204	204	204
Villages	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.09	0.09	14578.43	14578.43
Total effect	0.01	0.01	2157.88	1524.46
SE	0.03	0.03	4931.43	4978.10
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets. *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Standard errors clustered at the village level. Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) (* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 18: Money Spent on Chlorine, Deworming, and ORS (Share and Amount)

	<i>Dep. Var.: Money spent on:</i>					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	<i>Chlorine</i>		<i>Deworming</i>		<i>ORS</i>	
	<i>Share [0-1]</i>					
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.01 (0.03)	0.00 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)	0.01 (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)
Age Set	0.00 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.05** (0.02)	0.04** (0.02)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)
Young Male Committee	0.01 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)
Observations	204	204	204	204	204	204
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.32	0.32	0.26	0.26	0.31	0.31
Total effect	0.01	0.02	0.01	0.01	-0.03	-0.03
SE	0.02	0.02	0.02	0.02	0.03	0.02
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets. *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Standard errors clustered at village level. Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

8. Effects on the Allocation of Health Products

The next line of inquiry investigates the distribution of these health products. On average, most households across both villagers and committee members receive at least one product – between 95% and 99%. There is no differential effect across treatment group. All chiefs receive at least one product.

Table 19 presents the number of tablets received by a household, estimated separately for villagers, committee members, and chiefs. First, villagers receive on average the fewest number of tablets – around 20, while committee members receive close to 30 and chiefs receive 45.

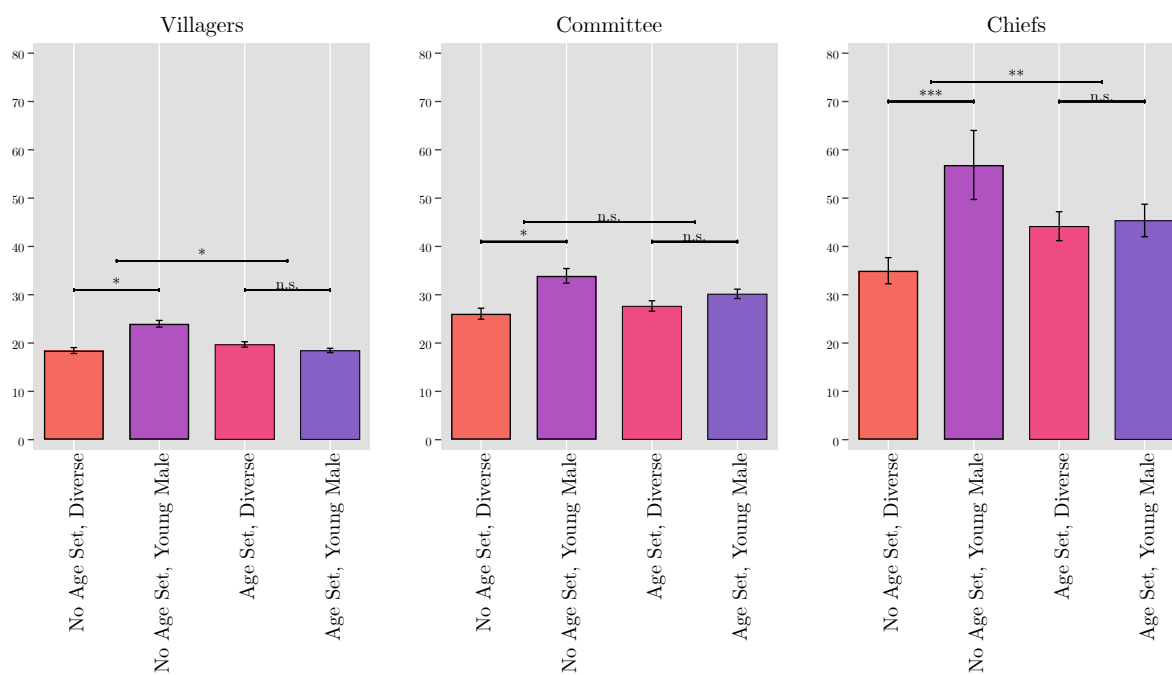
In columns 1 and 2, we find some evidence that households report receiving fewer tablets in villages with age sets and young male committees; however, the coefficient is no longer significant once we include village level controls. Columns 5 and 6 suggest that chiefs receive fewer twenty fewer tablets in age set villages with young male committees. The coefficient on young male committees is twenty-one – suggesting that young male committees in non-age set villages are particularly susceptible to influence and capture from the chief. This is seen clearly in Panel C of Figure 9, where in fact diverse committees in non-age set villages provide the most constraint on the chief. The negative and significant coefficient on age sets times young male is entirely driven chief capture in non-age set villages with young male.

Table 19: Number of Products Received by Villagers, Committee Members, and Chiefs

	Dep. Var.: Number of Products Received by...							
	(1) Villagers	(2)	(3) Committee Members	(4)	(5) Chiefs	(6)	(7) Share of Products Accounted For	(8)
Age Set × Young Male Committee	−6.756* (3.752)	−4.658 (3.103)	−5.345 (5.073)	−3.151 (4.506)	−20.689** (9.633)	−18.003** (8.996)	−0.030 (0.051)	−0.005 (0.046)
Age Set	1.265 (2.812)	1.164 (2.315)	1.597 (3.149)	2.023 (2.752)	9.217* (4.788)	11.649** (4.523)	0.040 (0.030)	0.035 (0.026)
Young Male Committee	5.527* (2.857)	2.401 (2.504)	7.837* (4.258)	4.408 (3.853)	21.875*** (8.198)	17.139** (7.794)	0.080*** (0.028)	0.043* (0.025)
Observations	3,121	3,121	1,112	1,112	202	202	204	204
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	19.985	19.985	29.411	29.411	45.312	45.312	0.217	0.217
Total effect	0.036	−1.094	4.090	3.280	10.403	10.785	0.089	0.074
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Figure 9: Number of Health Products Received



Notes: The figures display the heterogeneity in means for the number of products received by villagers, chiefs, and committee members, by treatment status and age set practices. The vertical brackets show ± 1 standard errors of the mean. At the top of the figure, we report tests across treatment status (bottom row of brackets) and of the interaction (top row). Statistical significance levels are shown as n.s. for not statistically significant, * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

8.1. Heterogeneity in Product Distribution

Thus far we have found evidence that young male committees in age set villages work together better. They feel closer to each other and perform more project tasks. This, however, does not seem to have a measurable effect on the amount of products that villagers report receiving. The primary exception is the chiefs, who report receiving fewer products in villages with age sets and young male committees. This suggests that perhaps chiefs are less able to “capture” the allocation of products in these villages.

We explore three forms of heterogeneity: heterogeneity by respondent closeness to chief, by closeness to committee members, and finally by respondent wealth. Respondents report how close they feel to the chief and committee members. The variable ranges from 0 to 5, increasing in perceived closeness. For the analysis by closeness to the chief and committee members we partition the samples by above and below median closeness.

The results of this heterogeneity analysis are presented in Table 20. We find evidence that respondents who identify as being close to the chief receive fewer products in age set villages with young male committees, though on average, these respondents receive more products than those not close to the chief in Table 20. This is consistent with the results where chiefs also receive fewer products, and it suggests that in age set villages with young male committees, chiefs are less able to capture the product allocation. We also present p-values testing the equality of the $AgeSet \times Young\ Male\ Committee$ coefficient across those close to the chief or not close to the chief.

We then turn to examining heterogeneity by those who report being close to the committee members relative to those who report not being close. In contrast to the analysis by proximity to the chief, we don’t find significant differences in allocations. The coefficient for $AgeSet \times Young\ Male\ Committee$ is not significantly different across those who are close to or not close to the committee members. Finally, we also explore heterogeneity by respondent wealth. Wealth is proxied by the enumerator, who rates all respondents from 1 to 5 based on the respondent’s house and appearance. Again, we partition the sample by above and below median wealth – but given that many respondents are quite poor, this results a smaller sample of those who are identified as wealthy. We find evidence that the distribution of products differs in age set villages with young male committees. Wealthy individuals receive fewer products in age set villages with young male committees. These results are significantly different from those who are not wealthy.

Table 20: Heterogeneity in Number of Health Products Received by Close to Chief

	Dep. Var.: Number of [...] tablets			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	Not close to Chief		Close to Chief	
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-4.381 (3.280)	-1.988 (2.674)	-9.740** (4.487)	-7.739** (3.755)
Age Set	0.808 (2.510)	-0.014 (2.154)	2.088 (3.427)	2.473 (2.766)
Young Male Committee	3.406 (2.512)	-0.114 (2.157)	7.820** (3.344)	5.187* (3.035)
P-value	0.096	0.033	.	.
Observations	1,455	1,455	1,661	1,661
Villages	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	17.489	17.489	22.188	22.188
Total effect	-0.167	-2.116	0.168	-0.079
	Not close to Committee		Close to Committee	
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-4.179 (3.310)	-2.598 (2.806)	-10.465** (5.089)	-7.303* (4.136)
Age Set	-0.067 (2.378)	-0.116 (2.130)	3.792 (4.120)	3.134 (3.216)
Young Male Committee	4.019 (2.585)	1.057 (2.264)	6.952** (3.456)	3.825 (3.173)
P-value	0.165	0.193	.	.
Observations	1,705	1,705	1,380	1,380
Villages	102	102	101	101
Mean Dep. Var.	17.597	17.597	23.173	23.173
Total effect	-0.227	-1.657	0.278	-0.344
	Wealth≤2		Wealth>2	
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-4.813 (3.418)	-3.235 (2.915)	-18.648*** (6.330)	-12.655** (5.306)
Age Set	-0.038 (2.534)	0.112 (2.220)	7.769 (4.701)	5.819 (3.528)
Young Male Committee	4.324 (2.745)	1.643 (2.439)	12.884*** (4.512)	7.049 (4.382)
P-value	0.012	0.049	.	.
Observations	2,596	2,596	525	525
Villages	102	102	97	97
Mean Dep. Var.	18.780	18.780	25.939	25.939
Total effect	-0.527	-1.480	2.005	0.213
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. Villagers close to chief report being close in a level 3 or above from a [1-5] scale. *Individual Controls* include: an indicator variable equal to 1 if villager is a male, age, and age squared. *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Standard errors are clustered at village level. Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*). The p-value is from a test of equality of the *Age Set × Young Male Committee* coefficients across sub-groups. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

8.2. *Health Outcomes*

One potential measure of project success is reduction in symptoms related to the types of diseases that the health products address. For example, use of chlorine tablets could potentially reduce incidence of diarrhea. Deworming pills could affect stomach pain or vomiting. Note, the ORS is used to prevent dehydration from diarrhea, rather than to prevent illness.

We construct household level measures of share of household members that have been sick in the last four weeks with diarrhea, vomiting, or stomach pains. We examine the average effect on health outcomes with the same samples as in the previous analyses. We find little evidence of effects on health outcomes. We also construct measures of share of children under five who have been sick. Similarly, we find no effects on health. These tables are presented in Appendix Tables [C8–C13](#).

9. **Conclusions**

The aim of this study was to better understand the importance of social and political structures for economic development. We considered a potentially important, yet unstudied, characteristic of many Africa societies: the presence of age sets, which are groups of men who move through life together collectively. Men who belong to the same age set overtime pass through different age grades, or phases of life. Groups of young men at approximately the same age are initiated into the age grade together and from then on form an age set. The initiation rituals are typically elaborate, lasting 6 months or longer, and occur outside of the village in remote secret locations.

A potential consequence of age sets, which has been documented in ethnographies, is that the presence of age sets creates a group of young men who are cohesive and strongly allied with one another. In the cases studied, these young men serve as a check on the power of the elders in the community, who are generally the political elite. Thus, age sets may serve as a check on the political authority of the elite of a society, increasing de facto political accountability.

Overall, our findings show that the effects of the particular program we examined – which like other recent initiatives aims to give some formal power to younger individuals in the village – depend on the presence of an important local custom, age sets. When age sets are present, then young male committees do generate groups that are more cohesive and engage more in oversight activities. In terms of product distribution, young male committees appear not to be

able to prevent unfair product distribution, which is not surprising given the fact our setting is strongly gerontocratic. When age sets are present, this adverse outcome is not present. These findings highlight the care that must be taken when attempting to alter the distribution of power in local villages. Our findings show that whether a particular intervention is beneficial or not can depend critically on the baseline social and political structure.

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Online Appendix for
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Appendix A. Committee and Chief Outcomes

Table A1: Chief Views of Committee

	(1) <i>Satisfaction with committee performance [1-5]</i>	(2) <i>Satisfaction with committee performance [1-5]</i>	(3) <i>Difficulty working with committee [1-5]</i>	(4) <i>Difficulty working with committee [1-5]</i>	(5) <i>Number of meetings with committee</i>	(6) <i>Number of meetings with committee</i>
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.394 (0.318)	0.345 (0.316)	−0.163 (0.369)	−0.116 (0.374)	0.013 (0.401)	0.015 (0.404)
Age Set	0.017 (0.227)	0.127 (0.223)	0.075 (0.278)	0.057 (0.286)	0.419** (0.207)	0.453** (0.218)
Young Male Committee	−0.306 (0.243)	−0.268 (0.256)	0.283 (0.276)	0.218 (0.288)	−0.010 (0.300)	−0.023 (0.307)
Observations	202	202	202	202	202	202
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	4.089	4.089	1.995	1.995	2.337	2.337
Total effect	0.105	0.205	0.195	0.159	0.422	0.445
SE	0.210	0.224	0.254	0.268	0.277	0.279
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: Village Controls include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. Age Set is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, Young Male Committee is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Satisfaction with committee performance is the chiefs self-reported satisfaction with the committee. Difficulty working with committee is the chief's response to: "Overall, how difficult was it to work with the village committee for this project." Number of meetings with committee is the chief's account of how many times he met with committee members. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A2: Committee Views of Chief

	(1) <i>Satisfaction with chief performance [1-5]</i>	(2) <i>Satisfaction with chief performance [1-5]</i>	(3) <i>Difficulty working with chief [1-5]</i>	(4) <i>Difficulty working with chief [1-5]</i>	(5) <i>Difficulty working with other committee [1-5]</i>	(6) <i>Difficulty working with other committee [1-5]</i>
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.099 (0.267)	0.053 (0.270)	0.125 (0.273)	0.150 (0.275)	0.051 (0.136)	0.069 (0.141)
Age Set	0.174 (0.151)	0.219 (0.155)	−0.421** (0.162)	−0.422** (0.166)	0.067 (0.100)	0.039 (0.102)
Young Male Committee	−0.154 (0.229)	−0.097 (0.233)	0.091 (0.244)	0.049 (0.246)	−0.056 (0.105)	−0.072 (0.113)
Observations	1,110	1,110	1,109	1,109	1,110	1,110
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	4.182	4.182	1.769	1.769	1.589	1.589
Total Effect	0.119	0.176	−0.205	−0.223	0.062	0.036
SE	0.160	0.168	0.171	0.178	0.100	0.107
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: Village Controls include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. Age Set is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, Young Male Committee is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Satisfaction with committee performance is the chiefs self-reported satisfaction with the committee. Difficulty working with committee is the chief's response to: "Overall, how difficult was it to work with the village committee for this project." Number of meetings with committee is the chief's account of how many times he met with committee members. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Appendix B. Product Distribution

Table B3: Product Received from Chief, Committee, or Both

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	<i>Any product received from:</i>					
	<i>chief [0/1]</i>	<i>committee [0/1]</i>	<i>chief or committee [0/1]</i>			
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-0.134 (0.081)	-0.120 (0.082)	0.061 (0.134)	0.014 (0.128)	0.027 (0.128)	0.072 (0.122)
Age Set	-0.027 (0.053)	-0.031 (0.054)	0.121 (0.090)	0.133 (0.086)	-0.093 (0.090)	-0.097 (0.093)
Young Male Committee	0.121 (0.074)	0.101 (0.076)	-0.081 (0.104)	-0.012 (0.102)	-0.006 (0.098)	-0.073 (0.099)
Observations	3,137	3,137	3,137	3,137	3,137	3,137
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.117	0.117	0.376	0.376	0.436	0.436
Total effect	-0.040	-0.050	0.101	0.135	-0.072	-0.098
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set* × *Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B4: Product Received from Chief, Committee, or Both by Product Type

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	<i>chief</i> [0/1]		<i>Product received from:</i> <i>committee</i> [0/1]		<i>chief or committee</i> [0/1]	
	<i>Deworming tablets</i>					
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-0.099 (0.076)	-0.082 (0.076)	0.054 (0.124)	0.019 (0.121)	0.049 (0.118)	0.090 (0.112)
Age Set	-0.037 (0.050)	-0.045 (0.050)	0.104 (0.083)	0.115 (0.081)	-0.093 (0.085)	-0.091 (0.087)
Young Male Committee	0.096 (0.068)	0.074 (0.069)	-0.072 (0.097)	-0.021 (0.095)	-0.022 (0.089)	-0.084 (0.088)
Observations	3,137	3,137	3,137	3,137	3,137	3,137
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.117	0.117	0.354	0.354	0.380	0.380
Total effect	-0.039	-0.054	0.086	0.112	-0.066	-0.085
	<i>Chlorine tablets</i>					
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-0.141* (0.079)	-0.126 (0.080)	0.089 (0.121)	0.049 (0.117)	0.017 (0.120)	0.058 (0.115)
Age Set	-0.024 (0.050)	-0.031 (0.051)	0.069 (0.081)	0.080 (0.077)	-0.080 (0.085)	-0.075 (0.088)
Young Male Committee	0.136* (0.073)	0.116 (0.075)	-0.098 (0.096)	-0.040 (0.094)	0.012 (0.093)	-0.051 (0.093)
Observations	3,137	3,137	3,137	3,137	3,137	3,137
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.120	0.120	0.344	0.344	0.384	0.384
Total effect	-0.029	-0.042	0.060	0.089	-0.051	-0.068
	<i>ORS packs</i>					
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-0.133* (0.077)	-0.119 (0.078)	0.032 (0.120)	-0.003 (0.117)	0.009 (0.119)	0.050 (0.114)
Age Set	-0.023 (0.053)	-0.029 (0.054)	0.118 (0.083)	0.123 (0.080)	-0.085 (0.085)	-0.083 (0.087)
Young Male Committee	0.111 (0.071)	0.092 (0.073)	-0.061 (0.093)	-0.009 (0.093)	-0.005 (0.091)	-0.066 (0.092)
Observations	3,137	3,137	3,137	3,137	3,137	3,137
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.116	0.116	0.350	0.350	0.369	0.369
Total effect	-0.044	-0.057	0.089	0.111	-0.081	-0.100
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

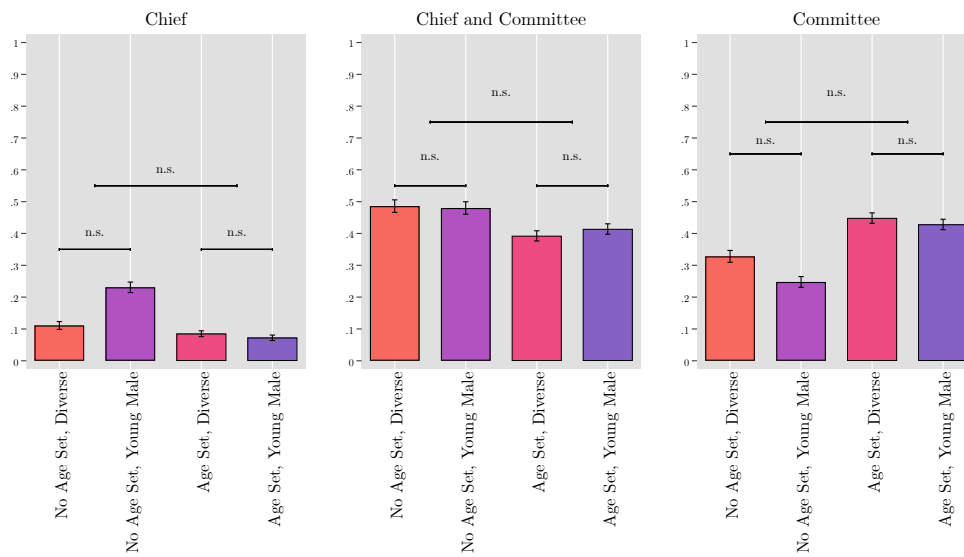
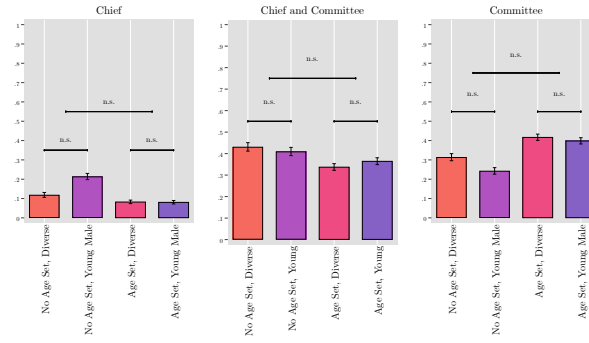


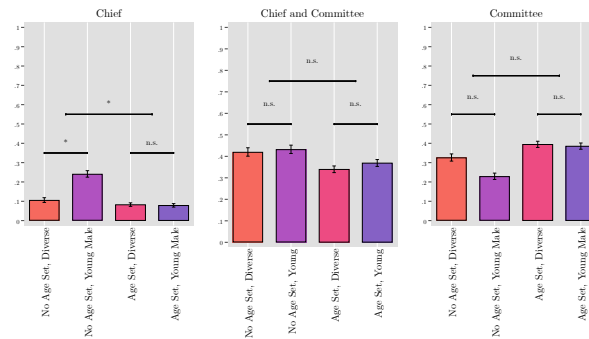
Figure B1: Products Received from Chief, Committee, or Both

Notes: The figures display the means for the share of products (chlorine tablets, ORS packs and deworming tablets) received from chiefs, committee members or both; by treatment status and age set practices. The vertical brackets show ± 1 standard errors of the mean. At the top of the figure, we report tests across treatment status (bottom row of brackets) and of the interaction (top row). Statistical significance levels are shown as n.s. for not statistically significant, * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

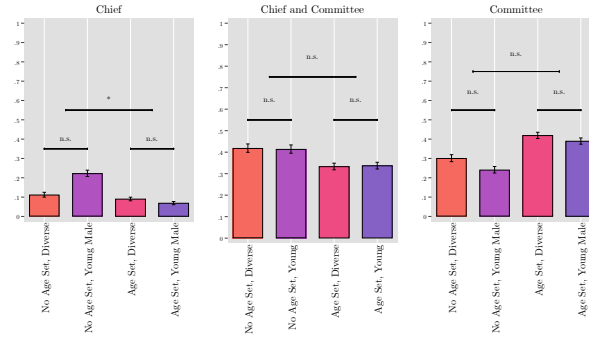
Figure B2: Product Received from Chief, Committee, or Both, by Product Type



(a) Deworming tablets



(b) Chlorine tablets



(c) ORS packs

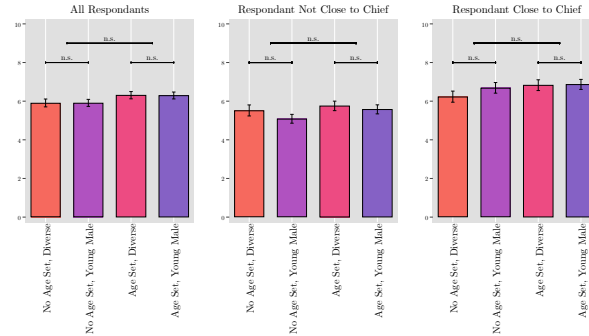
Notes: The figures display the means for the share of products (chlorine tablets, ORS packs and deworming tablets) received from chiefs, committee members or both; by treatment status and age set practices. The vertical brackets show ± 1 standard errors of the mean. At the top of the figure, we report tests across treatment status (bottom row of brackets) and of the interaction (top row). Statistical significance levels are shown as n.s. for not statistically significant, * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table B5: Heterogeneity in Number of Health Products Received by Product by Close to Chief

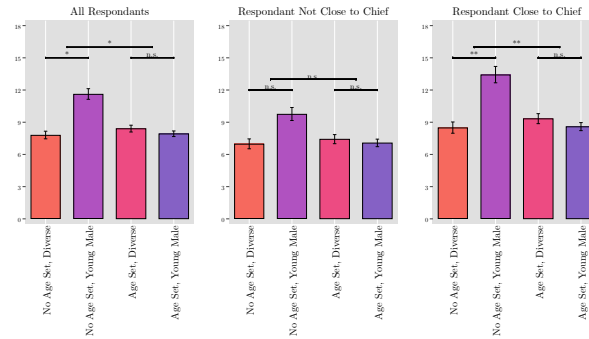
	Dep. Var.: Number of [...] tablets					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	All Respondents		Respondents Not close to Chief		Respondents Close to Chief	
	Deworming tablets					
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.014 (0.754)	0.440 (0.657)	0.390 (0.831)	0.897 (0.736)	-0.469 (0.892)	-0.081 (0.780)
Age Set	0.407 (0.639)	0.266 (0.542)	0.121 (0.638)	-0.177 (0.546)	0.703 (0.799)	0.640 (0.688)
Young Male Committee	-0.013 (0.496)	-0.626 (0.479)	-0.464 (0.565)	-1.232** (0.546)	0.446 (0.580)	-0.024 (0.563)
P-value: Equality of Age Set x Young Male Committee coefficients	.	.	0.329	0.212	.	.
Observations	3,121	3,121	1,455	1,455	1,661	1,661
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	6.140	6.140	5.515	5.515	6.688	6.688
Total effect	0.408	0.081	0.047	-0.512	0.680	0.534
	Chlorine tablets					
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-4.326* (2.346)	0.440 (0.657)	-3.362 (2.124)	-2.092 (1.865)	-5.663** (2.723)	-4.695* (2.441)
Age Set	0.591 (1.431)	0.266 (0.542)	0.629 (1.342)	0.312 (1.246)	0.806 (1.649)	1.228 (1.415)
Young Male Committee	3.833* (1.970)	-0.626 (0.479)	2.835 (1.760)	0.988 (1.616)	4.937** (2.318)	3.595* (2.158)
P-value: Equality of Age Set x Young Male Committee coefficients	.	.	0.211	0.133	.	.
Observations	3,121	3,121	1,455	1,455	1,661	1,661
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	8.820	6.140	7.743	7.743	9.770	9.770
Total effect	0.098	0.081	0.102	-0.792	0.080	0.128
	ORS packs					
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-2.444** (1.176)	-3.257 (2.061)	-1.409 (1.000)	-0.793 (0.855)	-3.608** (1.495)	-2.962** (1.253)
Age Set	0.267 (0.911)	0.704 (1.264)	0.059 (0.758)	-0.148 (0.635)	0.579 (1.192)	0.605 (0.951)
Young Male Committee	1.708* (0.900)	2.208 (1.798)	1.034 (0.827)	0.129 (0.723)	2.437** (1.044)	1.616* (0.967)
P-value: Equality of Age Set x Young Male Committee coefficients	.	.	0.064	0.133	.	.
Observations	3,121	3,121	1,455	1,455	1,661	1,661
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	5.025	8.820	4.231	4.231	5.730	5.730
Total effect	-0.469	-0.345	-0.316	-0.813	-0.592	-0.742
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. Villagers close to chief report being close in a level 3 or above from a [1-5] scale. *Individual Controls* include: an indicator variable equal to 1 if villager is a male, age variable, age^2 . *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Standard errors clustered at village level. Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*). The p-value is from a test of equality of the *Age Set × Young Male Committee* coefficients across sub-groups. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

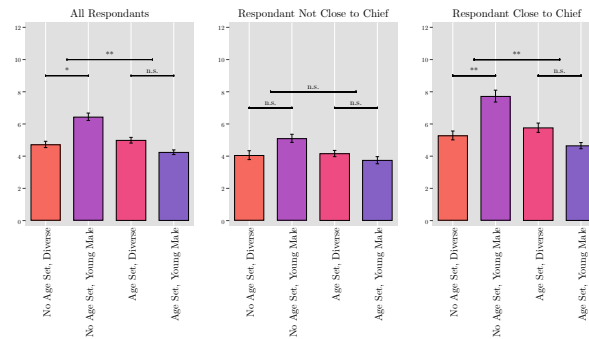
Figure B3: Heterogeneity in Number of Health Products Received by Product by Close to Chief



(a) Deworming tablets



(b) Chlorine tablets



(c) ORS packs

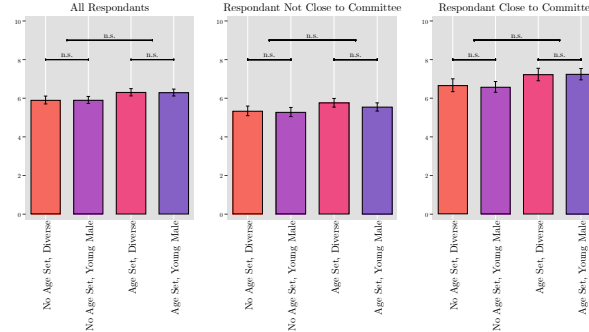
Notes: The figures display the heterogeneity in means for the number of products received by villagers, by treatment status, age set practices and the reported villager's closeness to chief. The vertical brackets show ± 1 standard errors of the mean. At the top of the figure, we report tests across treatment status (bottom row of brackets) and of the interaction (top row). Statistical significance levels are shown as n.s. for not statistically significant, * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table B6: Heterogeneity in Number of Health Products Received by Product by Close to Committee

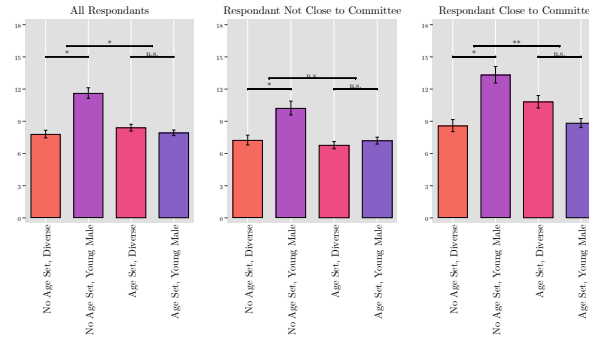
	<i>Dep. Var.: Number of [...] tablets</i>					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	All Respondents		Respondents Not Close to Committee		Respondents Close to Committee	
<i>Deworming tablets</i>						
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.014 (0.754)	0.440 (0.657)	-0.026 (0.789)	0.298 (0.736)	0.022 (1.045)	0.579 (0.900)
Age Set	0.407 (0.639)	0.266 (0.542)	0.317 (0.623)	0.207 (0.588)	0.676 (0.942)	0.402 (0.786)
Young Male Committee	-0.013 (0.496)	-0.626 (0.479)	-0.093 (0.549)	-0.695 (0.574)	-0.076 (0.646)	-0.619 (0.627)
P-value: Equality of Age Set x Young Male Committee coefficients	.	.	0.964	0.776	.	.
Observations	3,121	3,121	1,705	1,705	1,380	1,380
Villages	102	102	102	102	101	101
Mean Dep. Var.	6.140	6.140	5.521	5.521	6.978	6.978
Total effect	0.408	0.081	0.197	-0.190	0.621	0.361
<i>Chlorine tablets</i>						
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-4.326* (2.346)	0.440 (0.657)	-2.800 (2.065)	-1.996 (1.843)	-6.721** (3.051)	-5.065* (2.652)
Age Set	0.591 (1.431)	0.266 (0.542)	-0.288 (1.230)	-0.222 (1.150)	2.222 (2.040)	2.111 (1.679)
Young Male Committee	3.833* (1.970)	-0.626 (0.479)	3.045* (1.751)	1.533 (1.600)	4.737* (2.415)	3.088 (2.258)
P-value: Equality of Age Set x Young Male Committee coefficients	.	.	0.120	0.151	.	.
Observations	3,121	3,121	1,705	1,705	1,380	1,380
Villages	102	102	102	102	101	101
Mean Dep. Var.	8.820	6.140	7.694	7.694	10.321	10.321
Total effect	0.098	0.081	-0.043	-0.685	0.239	0.133
<i>ORS packs</i>						
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-2.444** (1.176)	-3.257 (2.061)	-1.352 (1.092)	-0.900 (0.959)	-3.766** (1.596)	-2.817** (1.267)
Age Set	0.267 (0.911)	0.704 (1.264)	-0.096 (0.764)	-0.101 (0.677)	0.893 (1.344)	0.622 (1.019)
Young Male Committee	1.708* (0.900)	2.208 (1.798)	1.067 (0.904)	0.219 (0.811)	2.291** (1.008)	1.356 (0.922)
P-value: Equality of Age Set x Young Male Committee coefficients	.	.	0.093	0.085	.	.
Observations	3,121	3,121	1,705	1,705	1,380	1,380
Villages	102	102	102	102	101	101
Mean Dep. Var.	5.025	8.820	4.382	4.382	5.874	5.874
Total effect	-0.469	-0.345	-0.381	-0.782	-0.581	-0.839
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Individual Controls* include: an indicator variable equal to 1 if villager is a male, age variable and age^2 . *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gomena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Standard errors clustered at village level. Villagers close to committee members report being close in a level 3 or above from a [1-5] scale. Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*). The p-value is from a test of equality of the *Age Set × Young Male Committee* coefficients across sub-groups. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

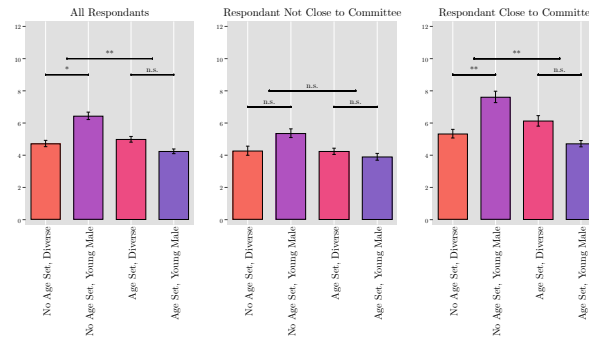
Figure B4: Heterogeneity in Number of Health Products Received by Product by Close to Committee



(a) Deworming



(b) Chlorine



(c) ORS

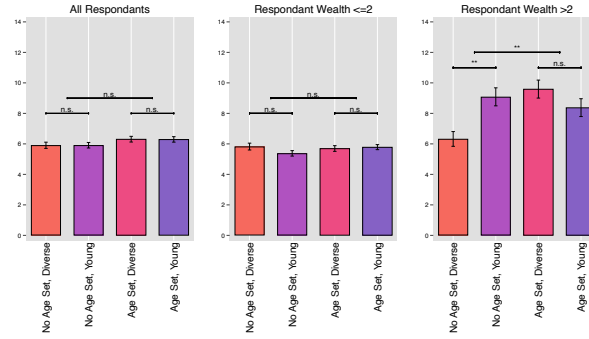
Notes: The figures display the heterogeneity in means for the number of products received by villagers, by treatment status, age set practices and the villager's closeness to committee members. The vertical brackets show ± 1 standard errors of the mean. At the top of the figure, we report tests across treatment status (bottom row of brackets) and of the interaction (top row). Statistical significance levels are shown as n.s. for not statistically significant, * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table B7: Heterogeneity in Number of Health Products Received by Product by Wealth

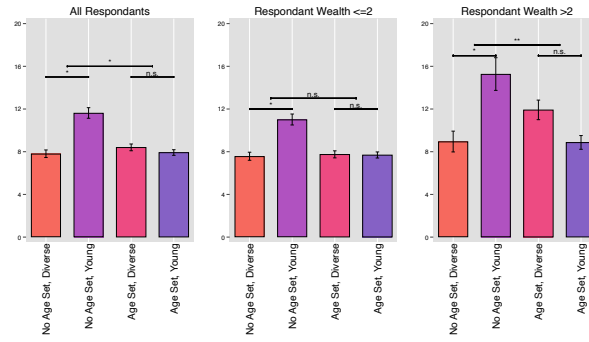
	Dep. Var.: Number of [...] tablets					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	All Respondents		Respondents Wealth <=2		Respondents Wealth >2	
Deworming tablets						
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.014 (0.754)	0.440 (0.657)	0.612 (0.662)	0.896 (0.604)	-3.937** (1.629)	-2.448 (1.519)
Age Set	0.407 (0.639)	0.266 (0.542)	-0.141 (0.557)	-0.254 (0.470)	3.236** (1.261)	2.736** (1.170)
Young Male Committee	-0.013 (0.496)	-0.626 (0.479)	-0.476 (0.474)	-0.931** (0.462)	2.751** (1.070)	1.298 (1.142)
P-value: Equality of Age Set x Young Male Committee coefficients						
	.	.	0.001	0.007	.	.
Observations	3,121	3,121	2,596	2,596	525	525
Villages	102	102	102	102	97	97
Mean Dep. Var.	6.140	6.140	5.679	5.679	8.417	8.417
Total effect	0.408	0.081	-0.004	-0.289	2.050	1.586
Chlorine tablets						
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-4.326* (2.346)	0.440 (0.657)	-3.548 (2.241)	-2.694 (1.990)	-8.806** (3.653)	-6.233* (3.441)
Age Set	0.591 (1.431)	0.266 (0.542)	0.185 (1.376)	0.430 (1.303)	2.504 (2.137)	1.801 (1.726)
Young Male Committee	3.833* (1.970)	-0.626 (0.479)	3.461* (1.908)	1.979 (1.743)	6.184** (3.094)	3.708 (3.159)
P-value: Equality of Age Set x Young Male Committee coefficients						
	.	.	0.133	0.335	.	.
Observations	3,121	3,121	2,596	2,596	525	525
Villages	102	102	102	102	97	97
Mean Dep. Var.	8.820	6.140	8.404	8.404	10.876	10.876
Total effect	0.098	0.081	0.098	-0.285	-0.118	-0.724
ORS packs						
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-2.444** (1.176)	-3.257 (2.061)	-1.877* (1.065)	-1.437 (0.937)	-5.905*** (2.109)	-3.974** (1.680)
Age Set	0.267 (0.911)	0.704 (1.264)	-0.082 (0.805)	-0.064 (0.691)	2.029 (1.633)	1.282 (1.156)
Young Male Committee	1.708* (0.900)	2.208 (1.798)	1.338 (0.856)	0.596 (0.771)	3.949*** (1.483)	2.043 (1.465)
P-value: Equality of Age Set x Young Male Committee coefficients						
	.	.	0.018	0.068	.	.
Observations	3,121	3,121	2,596	2,596	525	525
Villages	102	102	102	102	97	97
Mean Dep. Var.	5.025	8.820	4.697	4.697	6.646	6.646
Total effect	-0.469	-0.345	-0.620	-0.906	0.074	-0.649
Village Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Individual Controls* include: an indicator variable equal to 1 if villager is a male, age variable and *age*². *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Standard errors clustered at village level. Wealth is measured on a scale from [1-5] based on respondents appearance. Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*). The p-value is from a test of equality of the *Age Set × Young Male Committee* coefficients across sub-groups. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

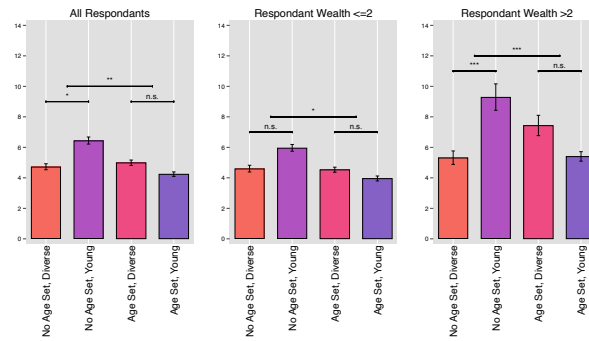
Figure B5: Heterogeneity in Number of Health Products Received by Product by Wealth



(a) Deworming



(b) Chlorine



(c) ORS

Notes: The figures display the heterogeneity in means for the number of products received by villagers, by treatment status, age set practices and the villager's wealth based on appearance. The vertical brackets show ± 1 standard errors of the mean. At the top of the figure, we report tests across treatment status (bottom row of brackets) and of the interaction (top row). Statistical significance levels are shown as n.s. for not statistically significant, * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Appendix C. Health Outcomes

Table C8: Health Outcomes by Close to Chief: Share of Household Members

	Dep. Var.: Share of Household Members Sick with...					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	All Respondents	Respondents Not close to Chief		Respondents Close to Chief		
	Average Effect: Diarrhea, Vomiting, Stomach Pain					
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.029 (0.072)	0.050 (0.068)	-0.022 (0.098)	0.008 (0.093)	0.054 (0.093)	0.057 (0.091)
Age Set	-0.030 (0.053)	-0.019 (0.050)	0.007 (0.062)	-0.004 (0.055)	-0.044 (0.070)	-0.019 (0.070)
Young Male Committee	0.011 (0.059)	-0.022 (0.055)	0.044 (0.073)	0.004 (0.069)	-0.013 (0.078)	-0.027 (0.075)
P-value: Equality of Age Set x Young Male Committee coefficients	.	.	0.562	0.669	.	.
Observations	3,133	3,133	1,458	1,458	1,670	1,670
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
SD	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000
Village and Individual Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Individual Controls* include: an indicator variable equal to 1 if villager is a male, age variable and *age*² *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Standard errors clustered at village level. Closeness to chief as assessed by villagers reported closeness (10-5], above or below 3). Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table C9: Health Outcomes by Close to Chief: Children Under 5

	Dep. Var.: Children under 5 Years Old Sick with...					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	All Respondents	Respondents Not close to Chief		Respondents Close to Chief		
	Average Effect: Diarrhea, Vomiting, Stomach Pain					
Age Set × Young Male Committee	-0.048 (0.063)	-0.036 (0.062)	0.047 (0.113)	0.063 (0.116)	-0.082 (0.075)	-0.072 (0.074)
Age Set	0.048 (0.039)	0.052 (0.042)	0.044 (0.051)	0.058 (0.059)	0.062 (0.054)	0.064 (0.057)
Young Male Committee	0.054 (0.046)	0.041 (0.047)	0.045 (0.053)	0.031 (0.061)	0.060 (0.058)	0.049 (0.058)
P-value: Equality of Age Set x Young Male Committee coefficients	.	.	0.377	0.378	.	.
Observations	3,136	3,133	1,458	1,458	1,670	1,670
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
SD	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000
Village and Individual Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Individual Controls* include: an indicator variable equal to 1 if villager is a male, age variable and *age*². *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Standard errors clustered at village level. Closeness to chief as assessed by villagers reported closeness ([0-5], above or below 3). Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table C10: Health Outcomes by Close to Committee: Share of Household Members

	Dep. Var.: Share of Household Members Sick with...					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	All Respondents	Respondents Not close to Committee		Respondents Close to Committee		
	Average Effect: Diarrhea, Vomiting, Stomach Pain					
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.029 (0.072)	0.050 (0.068)	0.003 (0.128)	0.038 (0.130)	0.027 (0.079)	0.047 (0.076)
Age Set	-0.030 (0.053)	-0.019 (0.050)	-0.082 (0.068)	-0.076 (0.080)	-0.014 (0.058)	-0.006 (0.057)
Young Male Committee	0.011 (0.059)	-0.022 (0.055)	0.082 (0.100)	0.051 (0.102)	0.002 (0.064)	-0.031 (0.061)
P-value: Equality of Age Set x Young Male Committee coefficients	.	.	0.997	0.909	.	.
Observations	3,133	3,133	503	503	2,593	2,593
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
SD	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000
Village and Individual Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Individual Controls* include: an indicator variable equal to 1 if villager is a male, age variable and *age*². *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Standard errors clustered at village level. Closeness as assessed by villagers reported closeness ([0-5], above or below 3). Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table C11: Health Outcomes by Close to Committee: Children Under 5

	<i>Dep. Var.: Children Under 5 Years Old Sick with...</i>					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	All Respondents		Respondents Not close to Committee		Respondents Close to Committee	
<i>Average Effect: Diarrhea, Vomiting, Stomach Pain</i>						
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.029 (0.072)	0.050 (0.068)	0.003 (0.128)	0.038 (0.130)	0.027 (0.079)	0.047 (0.076)
Age Set	-0.030 (0.053)	-0.019 (0.050)	-0.082 (0.068)	-0.076 (0.080)	-0.014 (0.058)	-0.006 (0.057)
Young Male Committee	0.011 (0.059)	-0.022 (0.055)	0.082 (0.100)	0.051 (0.102)	0.002 (0.064)	-0.031 (0.061)
P-value: Equality of Age Set × Young Male Committee coefficients	.	.	1.000	0.960	.	.
Observations	3,136	3,133	503	503	2,593	2,593
Villages	102	102	102	102	102	102
Mean Dep. Var.	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
SD	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000
Village and Individual Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Individual Controls* include: an indicator variable equal to 1 if villager is a male, age variable and age^2 . *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Standard errors clustered at village level. Closeness as assessed by villagers reported closeness ([0-5], above or below 3. Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table C12: Health Outcomes by Wealth: Share of Household Members

	<i>Dep. Var.: Share of Household Members Sick with...</i>					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	All Respondents		Respondents Wealth ≤ 2		Respondents Wealth > 2	
<i>Average Effect: Diarrhea, Vomiting, Stomach Pain</i>						
Age Set × Young Male Committee	0.029 (0.072)	0.050 (0.068)	0.050 (0.073)	0.069 (0.068)	-0.107 (0.131)	-0.086 (0.139)
Age Set	-0.030 (0.053)	-0.019 (0.050)	-0.029 (0.055)	-0.020 (0.051)	-0.033 (0.089)	-0.015 (0.096)
Young Male Committee	0.011 (0.059)	-0.022 (0.055)	-0.010 (0.057)	-0.042 (0.053)	0.142 (0.103)	0.121 (0.111)
P-value: Equality of Age Set × Young Male Committee coefficients	.	.	0.417	0.398	.	.
Observations	3,133	3,133	2,607	2,607	526	526
Villages	102	102	96	96	96	96
Mean Dep. Var.	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
SD	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000
Village and Individual Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Individual Controls* include: an indicator variable equal to 1 if villager is a male, age variable and age^2 . *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Standard errors clustered at village level. wealth based on appearance ([0-5], above or below village median). Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set × Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table C13: Health Outcomes by Wealth: Children Under 5

	<i>Dep. Var.: Children Under 5 Years Old Sick with...</i>					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	All Respondents		Respondents Wealth ≤ 2		Respondents Wealth > 2	
	<i>Average Effect: Diarrhea, Vomiting, Stomach Pain</i>					
Age Set $\times$ Young Male Committee	-0.048 (0.063)	-0.036 (0.062)	-0.047 (0.057)	-0.037 (0.055)	-0.101 (0.147)	-0.078 (0.167)
Age Set	0.048 (0.039)	0.052 (0.042)	0.051 (0.036)	0.054 (0.036)	0.044 (0.102)	0.044 (0.124)
Young Male Committee	0.054 (0.046)	0.041 (0.047)	0.047 (0.040)	0.035 (0.039)	0.100 (0.113)	0.092 (0.137)
P-value: Equality of Age Set $\times$ Young Male Committee coefficients	.	.	0.501	0.536	.	.
Observations	3,136	3,133	2,608	2,607	528	526
Villages	102	102	96	96	96	96
Mean Dep. Var.	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
SD	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000
Village and Individual Controls	N	Y	N	Y	N	Y

Notes: All analyses include a year fixed effect. *Individual Controls* include: an indicator variable equal to 1 if villager is a male, age variable and *age*². *Village Controls* include: estimated number of households in village at baseline and distance to Gemena. *Age Set* is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a village has age sets, *Young Male Committee* is an indicator equal to 1 if the village was randomly assigned to have a committee of young men. Standard errors clustered at village level. wealth based on appearance ([0-5], above or below village median). Total effect is the sum of the three coefficients (*Age Set $\times$ Young Male Committee*, *Age Set* and *Young Male Committee*) * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.